Lies, Revenge and Locked away Memories

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/50849245.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Child Adora & Catra & Scarlet (She Ra+OC), Teen Adora & Catra & Scarlet (She Ra+OC), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)/Reader, Catra (She-Ra)/Reader

Characters:
Lonnie and palls (She Ra), Their kinda background characters, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Black Claw (OC), Horde Soldiers (She-Ra), Scarlet is a vampireish creature, Brief C'yra (queen of Halfmoon)

Additional Tags:
Canonical Child Abuse, Or Just Child Abuse, Abusive Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Manipulative Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Child Soldiers, Life in the Horde (She-Ra), Scarlet Has Anger Issues (OC), Horde Adora (She-Ra), Fluff, Forehead Touching, Emotionally Repressed, Hurt/Comfort, Catra Has Issues (She-Ra), Horde upbringing (She Ra), Memory Magic, Memory Alteration, Torture, Friends to Lovers, Memory Loss, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Underage Drinking

Language:
English

Series:
Part 2 of Scarlet's reign

Stats:
Published: 2023-10-15 Completed: 2023-11-30 Words: 35,189 Chapters: 3/3

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by Scarlet_Ice

Summary

Scarlet has now been a couple weeks in the Horde, locked up in the Black Garnet room and left to stew on her agonizing thoughts of how she got here. But not today, today Shadow Weaver has decided to let her stay with the others for the first time, so maybe she won't be alone anymore.... She thinks as a prickly Cat girl and an energetic smiling Blond meet her again.

Then we jump to some years in the future to their time as teens, trying to figure themselves out and their life in this harsh place. Catra slowly having to accept that maybe having one more person to trust wouldn't be so bad in her pre teens while Adora happily takes on more responsibility according to Weaver.

We follow the trio as they handle normal Horde troubles while their step mother keeps a very close eye on her golden child.

This goes more into what Catra's, Adora's and Scarlets childhood would've been like. Since I didn't feel like I completely got that conveyed through the little time they were all together.

NOTICE: This is a prequal to Fang's, Claw's and a girl with a Sword. And I recommend reading chapters 1 and 2 of it before reading this, but if you want to go in blind you can since you'll only miss some context.

Notes

It has been a moment since this series has gotten a update, I give you this as a sort of prelude before we continue with Ascending warlords, a depraved Demigod and sprouting

Ethereal wings which is the name I'm going with atm. I'm wondering if I can shorten it but this really encompassing everything and I have a god damn theme going now....

Previous name was just Ascension which is fine but still, it's up for change but for now that's it. I might change demigod for titan but I'm not completely sure about that one.

Time line: at the very latest I will start uploading right on new year but in the meanwhile you'll have this and if you are interested there are two other catradora fics on my profile now.

Lastly I wasn't original planning on doing a one shot but a few commenters got me to reconsider, so those who mentioned a one shot or a prequal which this was original supposed to be before I noticed I was nearing 30k words, pat yourself on the back, I wouldn't really have thought of making this without you. FYI this will be a max of 3 chapters long.

Now ok last, last thing if you're interested in getting updated on when I post remember to either sub or I guess bookmark the work, though in the second you'll have to check yourself if it's updated. You can also bookmark the collection Scarlet's reign or sub to my account in which case you should be notified when I post.

With that thanks for reading and leave your thoughts, if not just leave a like, it lets me know if you enjoy this sort of content and helps me immensely.

See the end of the work for more notes

Horde Hospitality

Horde Hospitality

The Fright Zone, mage district, 11 years before Thaymor

Sitting by a cold metal desk a little girl with crimson-colored eyes emptily stared down at the sheet of paper with weird symbols and written in big black letters. Basics of magic, level zero. While an elven woman by the front clad in dark purple robes prattled on, not that she was hearing any of it. Only the sound of air being blasted through the numerus vents above being registered as the world around her felt miles away. The muffled murmurs of the other cadets and their teacher just fading into the background as everyone blurred out.

Stare, stare at the paper is what she did, untouched, none of the questions answered, not that she could make heads or tails of it. Lip quivering her brows furrowed and head fell. Only memories plagued the little girl's mind, arrows, dad's head rolling on the forest floor, body collapsing..... Mom reaching a bloodied hand, *caressing my cheek as the red in her eyes waned, her skin going gray . Yet she smiled, fingers scratching the back of my neck like when she'd put me to sleep before kissing my forehead, saying goodnight for the last time....* ..

It only made the tightness in Scarlet's chest constrict even more, making her almost gasp for air as wet splotches littered the paper laid before her. Fingers clutching the sides of the desk, that sadness warped ten times over, angulating between despair and rage as she played it over and over again inside of her head, the emotions feeling as raw as when it happened.

“Hence using magic, you all might be able to help us fight off the princesses if you work hard enough, further aptitude tests will be taken during your time studying magic, now you all may return to your squads and after the next measuring we will see how many of you will be returning. Dismissed”

Arm flying up to her face drying the tears away, Scarlet looked in question as everyone left their papers on their desks filled with answers. Unlike hers..... Some students glanced at her with very peculiar looks in their eyes, some indifferent others almost teasing. Probably at the fact her eyes were all puffy. In the short week she’d been let out of her cage Scarlet had quickly noticed most of them had been here much longer than her and were oddly mean and jerky..... Not that she’d tried to be friends with them but any time she was on the cusp of crying or just completely lost a lot of them would go out of their way to annoy her.

Most, except a blond missing a front tooth and almost always sporting a big toothy smile who’d for now been the complete opposite. *Where the hell am I?* Rang in her ears, a question she’d been asking for the couple of weeks she’d been in the Horde now. Whatever the Horde was...

Stepping outside into the brightly lit gray and dark green hallway her foot hit something sending Scarlet tumbling arms in front. A heavy thud rang out as her hands smashed first into the floor while giggles erupted by her side.

“What the hell is your problem?!” she yelled glaring at the group of mismatched kids by the door.

“Oops, didn’t you see I was standing here?” the orange haired girl with tan skin asked while shrugging nonchalantly.

“In the doorway? Psht yeah right, that wasn’t funny, apologize” her brown eyes widened with one brow furrowing for just a moment, before exploding into laughter.

“Why should I? You tripped on me; freak why don’t you go cry to your mommy instead of annoying everyone with your pathetic sniffling” Scarlet’s jaw worked up and down, but words didn’t come from her utter disbelief. *Mom and dad always said to be nice to others, but nobody here seems to be even remotely likable or decent for that matter* .

“She’s such a looser”

“Yeah, I pity the squad she’s in”

“She’s gonna be held back in the first year for sure” a blue lizard, a boy covered in brown fur with yellow pupilless eyes, and another black-haired girl said while their friends nodded and held their stomachs, laughing along.

“Uuu, she’s getting mad, watch out” their ringleader continued as Scarlet growled out “apologize!”

“No-” was all she got out as a heavy smack! Reverberated around everyone present.

Towering over her, Scarlet glared down at the girl whose eyes now glistened with tears as blood gushed out from under her twisted nose bone “who's crying now! HUH?! You piece of garbage!” the scent almost immediately hit her nostrils and four front teeth burned with hunger as she salivated, already being able to taste it.

“Iiick!” the other human stumbled back as her friends trembled while shielding themselves, those white silhouette like arms filled with different colored roots spreading inside.

Arm rising the anger inside of her still fresh from the massive gash her parents' deaths had left boiled over, all care for their words and encouragements from before vanishing in an instant about being caring and kind. *You don’t deserve any kindness!* She screamed in her mind when a chill cold enough to reach her bones froze her in place.

“Scarlet... What have we talked about using, that?” the shadowy voice cooed as the vampires' head fell again under the little flickering lights that were left, the world changing back to it's normally colored self...

“I’m sorry miss Weaver..... They were being mean and tripped me because they thought it’d be funny, then none of them would apologize”

A bony gray hand set itself on her head, spindly fingers patting it tenderly “do not create excuses, you must control yourself or you’ll cause problems for everyone around you” Shadow Weaver tutted.

“B-but-”

“No buts, I don’t want to hear it, though it seems these cadets did in fact antagonize you to start this fight, so three days without ration bars should do, even so my dear you must do better, because I know you can” Scarlet just nodded somberly “now, let's go to Adora shall we?”

At that her head jerked up, nodding eagerly to the masked woman’s approval and Scarlet could swear those white eyes clearly a part of the mask moved “good girl~”

They passed jagged walls and corridors, weird stations, some gray guards with green visors and even a window she hadn’t seen on the way here. Massive houses made from steel and rock existed as far as the eye could see. All with their own red or green lights, even yellow and orange so high she couldn’t see the top from here. Scarlet awed at it all. In here she’d felt cramped, thinking they were just inside one house or underground or something but no.

In her momentary excitement she was quickly pulled forward as Weaver and her walked hand in hand, the robed woman not

stopping while gliding over the floor “the lesson went well I presume?”

Scarlet gulped, the woman holding her hand while probably having saved her, also made her blood go cold for some reason... “I don’t know..... I didn’t understand.....” more like she didn’t listen, but she wasn’t going to admit to that.

Weaver sighed pulling her arm up so they were side to side “I see we’ll have to give you special lessons, it should come quite naturally to you, since you are strong” pursing her lips, Scarlet kept her eyes on the floor.

“I am?”

“Yes, which is why you must work hard so you can stay by Adora’s side, it's what you want, remember?”

Again, Scarlet nodded “she’s nice, and she smells good” Weaver hummed suddenly as they turned the corner and Scarlet almost bolted forward.

Arm being yanked back her head snapped back to Weaver “before you go inside, you will drink this and then you are dismissed” tension clung to the air like water to a napkin and Scarlet instinctively knew.

“Yes, miss Weaver” she bowed quickly, taking the red vial before chugging it in one go.

“Now go on, and tell Adora to rest well before tomorrow's lessons”

“I will” Scarlet answered as a red pin on Weaver’s robe pinged, lighting up brighter making her sigh almost tiredly.

“Yes, I am on my way Andrew, no, I will not call you by your ridiculous new title and Grizzlor has barely become a force captain. He needs to learn patience, the northeastern front isn’t going anywhere, not to mention the amount of mediocrity in that entire region.... We still have a couple kingdoms to reduce to dust before we even reach the queen of thorns and her circle of druids, not to mention those accursed woods-” her voice trailed off while floating away, the bottom part of her robes angulating and waving in the air.

With Weaver turning the corner warmth suddenly returned in a surge as the lights did the same while further ahead everything still dimmed. Huffing Scarlet turned around to hear soft giggles coming from inside. Excitement filled her little heart as the double door's hydraulics churned before sliding to each side, revealing maybe twenty bunk beds, almost all occupied by kids of similar age to her.

Some turned to stare while others continued whatever antics they’d been doing. But she wasn’t here for any of them, her new admittedly almost rock-hard bed was further in the back, right

beside the person she wanted to say hi to. So, striding forward she didn't pay mind to the others, simply quickly passing any group standing in the middle of the room with a hop to her step, almost gliding past them like they weren't even there.

"Hold up, new kid" Scarlet's head turned brow arched and finger pointed to herself.

"Yes, you, what's your name?" a girl with braided brown hair asked as the little group beside her glanced at her.

"Scarlet, I'm a bit busy so could we get to know each other later?" she asked but the second tan skinned person she'd met today this time with grayish brown eyes just shook her head.

"I know who you wanna go and meet but you're better off staying with us"

Scarlet cocked her head as a blond kid carrying a green lizard stepped forward "I'm Kyle that's Lonnie, and this is Rogelio, he's small now but he's a fast grower, somehow, he used to be the size of my arm!"

"A-aha? But why? If you wanna play or something, we should get Adora and Catra" Scarlet said precariously staring at the yellow eyed lizard whose tongue kept reaching out in regular intervals like he was tasting the air or something. *W-what, are you*?

“Psht” one of the other kids spat while the one beside him sighed “not Catra....”

“Yeah, she’s such a buzz kill...” Scarlet blinked, while she’d been out of the room with the large red rock she hadn’t been allowed to sleep in the bunks before today. So even though Catra seemed maybe shy? Always hiding behind Adora and being just a little rude, this was, a little weird.

“She doesn’t seem so bad; have you guys been doing things she’d like to do too? Or have you just been pushing her away when she doesn't wanna play and then bullying her when she gets mad?” the feeling Scarlet was getting from this considering how everyone acted here was similar to a group of meanies back in.... Harmstead.... Who purposefully did things to push the kids they didn’t like away....

“She hit me because I didn’t want Adora to be on her team for once, she’s also a sore loser...” Lonnie scoffed with crossed arms “and she plays dirty...” the other kids nodded except for Kyle who kept his eyes to the floor.

“Hmmm, well I’ll see for myself, see yah later”

“W-wai- ugh....” Lonnie reached out as Scarlet spun around curving her back to dodge the hand while waving with her own “bye”

Getting across the room, she barely didn’t bump into a couple more cadets holding mugs with toothbrushes in them exiting the back room before managing to tap a certain blond that was jumping up and down on the shoulder. Expressive light blue eyes and a toothy grin missing one at the front greeted her as the ecstatic blond swept up her hands with glee.

“Scarlet! You missed the first day of obstacle courses! You're coming tomorrow, right? It’s gonna be so much fun!”

“Uhhh, yeah I’m actually staying here from now on”

“Really!? Then we can finally have a sleepover! Catra isn’t this great?” peaking behind Adora’s head she saw the small feline narrowing her eyes with crossed arms. The blond had already known Scarlet for weeks, Weaver constantly bringing her to train in some hand-to-hand techniques and orientation. Meanwhile Catra’d only met her a few times, the first being by mistake and the others by her sneaking after the blond.

“Whatever, let's just go already before the others try to follow us”

“Oh, can I-”

“No, we’re going to, our, secrets spot” Scarlet flinched at how quickly Catra snapped at her, hair standing up straight with her tail.

“Oh, come on Catra, we’ll have more fun together, and she’s nice I’ll bet you two will be great friends” Adora said putting a hand on the feline’s shoulder who promptly brushed it off.

“No, I’ll never be friends with someone like her, you’ve barely known her a week or something and you already want to show her our spot!”

“Catra it’s an abandoned closet, one more person won’t be a big deal and you know Weaver gave me the duty to take care of her, I can’t just leave her here” Catra hissed, and Scarlet sat down on her bed chin in her hands.

“It’s fine, if she wants to be a jerk then I don’t want to come” she pouted looking at the wall, completely dreading the moment they’d leave her alone with her thoughts already creeping in.....

“No, it’s okay-”

“It’s not, a-and you’re the jerk for just trying to invite yourself!” snorting her nose with tears brimming at the corners of her eyes, Scarlet’s head snapped back as she barked out.

“This is why no one wants to play with you! Because your selfish and just want Adora for yourself!” Catra froze only for a moment,

with her heterochromic eyes widening in shock before gritting her teeth and pouncing with a growl.

“NUH UH! They're just a bunch of stupid dumb faces who try to push me around all the time and they play stupid games!” small claws nicked into Scarlet’s arms as they held her while Catra tried to sit on her chest.

“She can have more than one friend you idiot!” Scarlet yelled, lodging a knee to her stomach before wrestling them both onto their sides.

The sheets rustled and the bed creaked as a crowd started forming. Catra yanking Scarlet’s ponytail, and her striking Catra’s chin with the underside of her palm before getting kicked in the hip by a clawed foot. Adora hovered over them trying to pull them apart when Scarlet kicked off the bed sending Catra onto her back before they all rolled with the mattress onto the cold steel floor.

“Ow!”

“OOF!”

“Agh!” they all yelped in unison.

Fallin on her back Scarlet quickly rolled, getting on one knee as Catra on all fours gave her a fanged hiss, spiked mane like hair standing aggressively. The whites of her eyes turning black, fangs sprouted out of her maulers as she hissed back wh-

“STOP! FRIENDS SHOULDN’T FIGHT LIKE THIS, and all of you go back to your bunks!” Adora shouted, squinting with one eye and standing right in the middle of them, palms raised up against both of them.

“She’s no-”

“Catra!” the feline’s face snapped down to the side glaring at a random corner in the room.

Meanwhile Scarlet could see Lonnie let out an amused huff as she mouthed *told you so* before patting her friends on the back and walking away. But a quick glance up made her stomach drop as the blond frowned, one bruised eye darkening.

“I-I’m....” she tried but the lump in her throat only got bigger.... *She’s gonna hate me now, I hurt her friend and her, I’m so stupid why couldn’t I just let it go??*

“Sit!” the blond ordered, pointing at Scarlet’s bunk.

She swallowed, keeping her eyes on the ground as Catra crossed her arms and just leaned up against the upper bunks support beam with a scowl. Picking up the mattress she slotted it onto the plaque of dark steel that was her new bed, no buoyancy or resemblance of softness.... Her pajamas probably burnt in the

husk that'd been her home.... The silky sheets mom used to clean with something that made it smell like, home..... Gone.

Snapping back to reality the light brown large wooden bed was gone, replaced by this metallic abomination that even with the thin mattress couldn't alleviate how hard and uncomfortable it was, even smelling like, nothing at all... Sitting down she sunk maybe ten centimeters before hitting the steel, hands resting on her thighs.

"I'm sorry" she quickly bowed "I didn't mean to hurt your feelings, or you.... Can we get ice from somewhere? Your eye, its gonna swell otherwise"

"What this? It's nothing it'll heal on its own, can't really be considered even a scratch" Adora pointed to her eye with a smile before frowning towards the feline "she apologized, now it's your turn" Scarlet couldn't believe her ears or eyes. *Is this a small thing? What? Do you get bruises like this regularly....* ..

"Mmmm...." Catra pouted.

"Don't be like that, she didn't mean it in a bad way, you should be a little kinder to others"

"Hmpf!"

Adora sighed, shoulders falling forward defeatedly “at least let her come with, Catra..... Or I might just stay here if you're gonna be a brat, I need to catch some shut eye anyway” the felines eyes were like daggers as they cut into the blond who was surprisingly unphased by the clearly hurt glare.

“Fine, she can come, but not because I feel bad or because you said so” Catra said brushing past the smirking blond.

Pfft “ok, whatever you say” Adora then giggled wrapping her arms around her friend and kissing the side of her head making the feline completely freeze “thank you”

“L-let's just go! Stupid..... Dora...” she squeaked before murmuring with a pinkish warm hue growing on her cheeks as she rubbed one bicep rapidly.

“Coming?”

“Umm... I don’t want to come in-between you two.... It-”

“It’s fine, she’s just a little grumpy because the others tried to slow her down on the obstacle course earlier” Adora whispered while hugging onto Scarlet’s arm.

“Shouldn’t we still get ice for-”

“Let's get it on the way, maybe get you a band aid or two too”

“Let's just get the ice for you two, ok? I’m fine, see? Not a scratch on me” the blond blinked before lifting her arm and running her fingers over thw slightly ripped sleeves.

“Wow.... Where did they go-”

“Are you two coming? The next guard shift’s gonna be here soon”

“Stop running ahead all the time! And maybe you wouldn’t have to wait” Adora grinned to Catra’s frown while the blond pulled the now lightly smiling Scarlet forward.

“Let's go then!” she giggled, patting Catra’s shoulder as they passed who got this feral look in her eye.

“Oh, it’s on now, last one there is a rotting ration bar!”

Fright zone, 2 years and 1 month before Thaymor, location, ???

One after another, droplets of water plinked somewhere nearby in this darkness. Even if this dry cloth wasn’t wrapped around Adora’s eyes she doubted she could see anything, this room having been built without lamps and all.... Not that it mattered, the blond didn’t have time to worry about that right now...

Adora’s bare knees felt sore after hours in the same position, her legs having become quite numb a while ago. A small tug on the arms behind her back only reminded her the two weights around her wrists weren't just that, but a pair of blocky restraints chained to a wall. Every movement made them jingle, same with the ones around her ankles also basically bolting her to the floor.

If that wasn’t enough, shivers constantly ran through her body while goosebumps littered her skin. Taking a deep breath in Adora’s chest hurt, with even that little movement making her joints creak internally, muscles aching at being reminded they could relax just momentarily. Only for mist to exit Adora’s mouth as her jaw trembled while her teeth chattered together. The floor physically hurt to touch but if she didn’t move that feeling got easier to handle, yet nothing could stop her from tensing every muscle constantly as the freezing temperature assaulted her raw skin.

Even so Adora didn’t whine, the only sound her letting out being the constant heavy exhalation and sharp painful inhalation trying to stay steady, trying to stay strong and composed for the two on her sides. Adora could feel Catra wasn’t going to hold on for much longer... She’d always hated the cold while Scarlet for some reason had stopped trembling after the first two days of this.

Shoulder to shoulder they stayed, Catra's tail being wrapped around Adora's calf as they all exhaled together before inhaling again, vapors of mist brushing their faces while the sides of those two's heads leaned on her shoulders. Periodically Adora would check by brushing her cheek into their foreheads how they were holding up, but at this point she only got one-word responses out of either.

Hip to hip they'd endured for who knows how long-

Heavy locks echoed throughout the almost completely empty room as a steel door swung open slamming into the wall with a boom.

"Well, what do we have here, you're still alive. Unfortunately, today we will not be using towels and water or stun batons, though this might sound pleasing to you I wouldn't celebrate too soon" the man paused pacing in front of them, boots stomping on the floor by their knees.

"So, no snark today? I see we're getting somewhere, even so, remember our fun little session we had in the middle of the week and at the start? It's time to try again" another set of footsteps joined his and blue light suddenly filled Adora's vision as the blindfold was pulled off.

A large blue magic circle engulfed them all, Catra hissing as Scarlet grunted at the sudden light blinding them all. Then suddenly, there was a pull inside of her chest traveling up to her

head making her feel light, docile and almost calm. You could say giving even...

“Now, tell us the access codes and we will all go home, this can all be over in an instant if you just so wish, not that there’s a point to resisting a truth spell” the wrong end of a baton grated under Adora’s chin making her stare into his yellow eyes.

“Tsk, w-what where t-the codes a-again Catra?”

“Pfft.... g-giving up a-already Dora?”

“I’m hungry just s-spit it out” Catra cracked her neck before cocking her head at the man incredulously.

“Well, I t-think it w-was 495-79-215-66666" he looked to his colleague who inputted the numbers into his pad making it bleep red.

“Wrong, this must be painful for you, the truth spell shocks the mind-”

“Oh Catra, you gave him your locker code, your favorite number, how did you fumble this idiotically?” Adora giggled, head falling onto the felines.

“I don’t know, he asked for access codes, so I gave it to him, you have to be more specific” she cackled as the force captain grumbled just before Adora’s cheek stung with a smack.

“You think this is a game? I will have those access codes-”

“Fucking touch her again **AND I’LL SHOVE THAT BATON INTO THE HOLE I’LL MAKE WHERE YOUR DICK SHOULD’VE BEEN** ” Adora jumped the chains yanking back as the bolts in the floor groaned against Scarlet’s bulging legs making Adora wonder which would give out first.

The instructors stumbled back at the inhuman shout like tens of voices layered on top of each other, clearly not having expected the previously only glaring red eyed girl’s outburst. Adora leaned to her left setting her head on Scarlet’s shoulder as the chains on her arms started to churn, a bolt grating its way towards the surface, bending the floor and itself.

“You’d make him a woman? Well s-shit Scar that’d be hilarious if the picture in my head didn’t make me want to violently vomit...” Catra wavered, head tilting to look at them both with worry.

“Scar it’s ok, I’m not hurt, it only stings a little compared to the rest” those glowing eyes dropped to her, the whites having turned pitch black. Yet the Blond's presence seemed to slow Scarlet’s breathing, make her sit back down even if she could probably tear herself free.

The force captain stepped forward again having recomposed himself “you still have this much energy? I think this concludes this evaluation, unlock them”

“Ugh.....” grunting Adora massaged her wrist after the cuffs clinked to the floor before bending her knees and almost falling forward as her legs readjusted to walking again.

Shakily, slowly she straightened up, feet finally stumbling into a standing position. It felt so freeing to walk again, yet her balance was awful as proper feeling returned past her knees and the little amount of strength, she had left warmed her thighs to life. A freezing cold arm pulled her in, letting Adora stay upright more securely. Catra’s gaze said it all while hobbling to their third and truthfully, she was worried too. Putting a hand on Scarlet’s lower back the tremble was back, the look in her eye was downright murderous as she glared holes into their instructors...

They had to limp back all the way in their gray Horde boxers and sports bra like some sort of twisted victory walk to the nearby locker room... When suddenly their cadet squadron's personal instructor met them halfway “excellent work, recovery stims will be waiting for you. You three also received the highest scores enduring the entire week of test time of this multifaceted interrogation program. As such you’ve now qualified for future positions in your promising careers”

“More like torture program....” Catra mumbled to Adora’s amused yet hoarse chuckle “thank you sir, we tried our best” she said already feeling the brunets' eyes rolling

“That you did, I won’t keep you, do take these few days to recover, you’ll be having a match against another squadron very soon”

“Ugh.... Already....”

“We’ll be fine by then, don’t worry, thanks for the heads up” instructor Cobalt nodded as the three waddled inside, arms on each other's shoulders before collapsing into the nearest slab of radiator.

Backs to the heated wall, together they slid down, groaning and heads falling onto the Blond's upper chest. Huddling for warmth in silence Adora could feel both of them tremble periodically. Catra’s nose was still running, and her teeth chattered, even when their backs were glued to the radiator and bodies to each other. For once even Adora didn’t have the energy to open her eyes, muscles feeling hollow and empty...

Lifting two shaky arms felt like someone’d tied two tons of lead around them, but still Adora wrapped them around Catra’s and Scarlet’s backs pulling them closer to no one's complaint. The fact the feline only wiggled to get closer without a single word of any kind made the blond open one dreary eyelid only to see her friend breathing peacefully, chest rising and falling with every big gulp of air she took.

One yellow eye peaked behind the curtains and Adora gave her a little smile before starting to rub circles into Catra’s shoulder when the curtain closed again. Next was the red-eyed girl whose half-

lidded gaze seemed so far away but was also by her previous reaction clearly running on fumes contrary to what you'd think an outburst like that would've meant.

She did the same for her as she did for Catra, reciprocating the little comfort she could give-

A faint cold suddenly swept over them as Scarlet's eyes lit up and Catra's breath caught while almost curling into Adora with her heartbeat skyrocketing. Squeezing them both contrary to normal Adora steeled herself to somehow, this time telling Weaver off. They weren't ready and, in this state, neither of her friends were in the right frame of mind to deal with her... Seconds passed, the air growing slightly cooler by the moment, yet the lights stayed the same and a shadow didn't creep up the floor like usual..... The locker room door's hydraulics churned and up slipped the door to reveal, a man? Clad in a trench coat red visored helmet on. But other than that, he seemed like a normal Horde soldier if not very tall with his right arm bulging under the fabric.

"Force commander Andrew" said with a quick salute "Shadow Weaver's return has been slightly delayed because of weather trouble by the Salinean border, so I'm here to give you these and a slightly revised message. I know how hard that test can be, I'm proud of all of you, you've done excellently"

"T-than-"

"Don't mention it, rest well" he said with a wave before spinning on his heel and exiting the locker rooms, Adora only catching a

quick glimpse of a red headed elf giving her a small smile before the door fell closed.

Three recovery stims sat by their feet and Adora sighed. How was she supposed to get to them with her body feeling like a rock and these two basically making her fall asleep?! They'd sighed in such relief when he entered and now the way they hugged onto her made Adora's nostrils flare. *And they dare deny how adorably cute they can be?! If anyone comes and wakes them up, I'll shove them in a locker. In the meanwhile, I'll just close my eyes for, a bit.....*.

3H and 47 minutes later

"Well, that was fucking pointless...." Scarlet spat out while furiously drying her black hair with strands of red in it, eliciting an eye roll out of Catra.

Scarlet always liked to get dramatic when they had to do things that in her mind didn't make sense, like cleaning duty. In her opinion it didn't benefit them whatsoever, though Catra had to agree with that one, it also extended all the way to something like interning guard duty. Pointless in her opinion but she just didn't understand all the upsides that came with it, especially since you only had to be in the same place or area on shift change Catra giggled internally and no one would question where you were, not really.

"Everyone in a commander cadet squadron had to do it Scar, besides it gives us an opportunity to learn how to resist truth

spells, also don’t break the sink I still need to use it” Adora said sounding like a broken record, always trying to see the so called positive in everything while Scarlet just groaned frustratedly while letting go of the creaking sink.....

“Ever the teacher's pet aren’t you, Dora? *Ow!*” Catra quipped getting an elbow to her side for it.

“I’m serious-”

“So am I, just don’t get captured problem solved” the blond frowned at her while tying her stupid hair poof and ponytail “you're not considering other possibilities”

“Ugh.... I say get good” Catra retorted glancing at Adora’s free hair swaying before it was swept away, the thought of running her fingers through it fleeting as she splashed cold water onto her face.

“Pft, at least they could keep it realistic if they do something like this, I mean come on, nO, YoU cAn’T tRy tO eScApE, tHaT’s AgAiNsT tHe RuLeS” Scarlet scoffed while doing a mock impression of their instructor.

Catra doubled over cackling, her stomach hurting from both that and hunger now, amazing “y-yeah and did you see their faces when you almost jumped them! Oh shit, I think someone needs to go change, the dude looked like he actually shit himself” Adora’s

lips scrunched like she was holding it in, but Catra knew the dork couldn’t stay composed if she just.

“C-Catra!” tackled her from the back! Without a shirt it was oh too easy to get to her sides!

“Pha-haha-hahaha-s-stop, stop! I c-can't” Adora snorted teary eyed barely staying upright while grabbing her arms “oh now you did it!”

“Wha- AGH!” Catra found herself back pressed into someone else who smirked down at her w-with a-a brush!

“NO!”

“Oh, come on, you practically did this to yourself, I’ll just get the knots out”

“Why do you want to torture me again!” Adora sat down on her lap still holding her wrists giggling sweetly as Scarlet pressed into her back, hand holding her head in an iron grip while the ball point ends scratched her scalp.

Catra’s jaw clenched, and muscles tensed trying to hold in a shiver at h-how, *no! I hate it* ! She shouted in her head as her head tugged back, the brush catching in her tangled mane.

“This would be easier if you just let me do this more often”

“Mhmm!” she tried shaking her head while scrunching her eyes shut, they were too close and Catra knew if she peaked her eyes would wander..... Why she felt so warm, why she’d found herself looking a little too long during training or while changing.... Catra had no idea why she felt so drawn and yet so afraid to even be seen looking... There was so much shame even when she’d rationalized.... *Ugh why am I so scared? It’s just stupid... Dora and Scar. . ... What’s so special about em? I’m toned too.... And I’m faster! And smarter, but they are warm.... STUPID!*

“Anyway, Adora in all realness that test was borderline atrocious, and don’t even try to deny it, because are you telling me you couldn’t have escaped if you tried?”

The blond grumbled while looking off to the side and Catra knew Scarlet was giving her a look-

Phrrrrr

The combing abruptly stopped and Catra’s eyes shot open to see Adora’s basically sparkling “d-did you just-”

“No!” she squeaked before getting squished between bulging biceps and forearms.

“That was-”

“Adorable!” the two finished each other's sentences as the brunet tried to flail her head feeling like a furnace... If it could, it probably would’ve been smoking from the embarrassment.

“Come on, do it again, please” Scarlet whispered while the brush almost euphorically scratched her scalp, pulling open knots as it pulled free before starting again.

“I don’t know what you're talking about....” she said biting down a whimper while feeling like she was about to cave when all their stomachs rumbled in unison.

Both girls squishing Catra with their bodies sighed sadly before stepping back making her feel cold even though the room temperature was high.... Somehow the intimacy had felt... Good, normally they’d just bump shoulders, wrestle or spar in training... The only other time feeling like this being just before when one or more of them were hurt.... Then no one would look at them weirdly or comment or belittle them for being physically close. The thought made Catra almost freeze as the two threw a shirt on, Scarlet tying her hair. They’d never have done that if someone else was around, Lonnie would’ve called her soft and weak...

Teeth pressing down on her lower lip, she pulled open her locker, fishing out a shirt before running her hands through her hair. It really was smoother, less tacky, yet she’d never ask Scarlet to do it again, that would be pathetic.... Yet slinking into the shirt she still felt a longing cold, the test having taken a toll on her.... She

wasn’t sure if she’d made it alone... Though maybe she would’ve, she always did after all with, her.....

“Hey, something wrong?” Catra’s eyes snapped open as an arm hooked around her shoulders and with it, warmth returned, radiating from the red-eyed girl.

“Nah, just ummm....”

“Tired and hungry right? Follow my lead” brow arching Catra stared at the grinning vampire whose eyes flew to the high held up arms, the blond stretching before letting go with a heavy relieved sigh.

“Doooora, you know how the mess hall is closed until morning?”

“Yeah? We’ll just have to wake up early-”

“We could or, you could swing by the infirmary you know, they’d give you the extra they have, and some more” Scarlet cooed waving a finger around while pulling Catra a little closer as the gears in her head started turning.

“I don’t know....”

“I know you’re hungry too, and if you bring a little extra to the others, they’ll suck up to you more- *IIK*” Catra yelped at the sudden pinch to her side “what was tha-” she whisper shouted at a frowning Scarlet.

“Come on, pleaseee, they’ll give it to you no problem” Scarlet pleaded by taking the Blond's hand and scurrying closer.

“Scar, stop..... We could get in trouble.....” Catra quickly spun wrapping her arms around Adora’s bicep and dropping her ears back.

“How are we supposed to perform tomorrow if something comes up, besides no one will know...”

“Not you too Cat...”

Their united assault was quickly cornering the Blond as they hooked their jaws over her shoulders staring up at her. Adora swallowed, those gray eyes almost becoming a light blue before groaning with a reddening face “fine, FINE! I give!”

“Yes!”

“Yes!” Catra and Scarlet jumped high fiving before spinning towards the door.

“But you two are coming with!” Adora basically fell on them, hooking her arms around their shoulders and pulling them under her “you’re such damn babies, you know that?”

“Wa, wa, let's get going already” Catra wa’d while Adora’s tender fingers tangled with her hair scuffing it in-between her ears.

Catra tensed again, ears flopping to the sides as pleasant shivers came like waves all the way down to her toes. How she didn’t want to but had to shake her head quickly like a cat would for Adora to stop unless she wanted another purring incident... If anyone else even touched her except these two they’d lose an eye, it was such a duality that she didn’t completely understand or maybe she did. Everyone else was annoying and they did promise they’d always stay together, no matter what. *I already conceded enough with Scarlet.... Even though Adora might’ve been right.... Not that she’ll ever know.*

The trip to the infirmary wasn’t long, and it still took them a good amount of time to get there because of their constant antics. It all starting with Catra trying to get back at Scarlet for forcefully combing her hair and the vampire teasing her for purring because of it, so *you must have liked it* and Catra immediately denying it. Adora being in the middle, basically came under crossfire immediately as they ran around her trying to get to the other.

“Will you two cut it out? We’re not twelve anymore- HAH, got you!” the blond rolled with Catra who yelped in a high-pitched tone before slinking out of her grasp.

“Ow, you trying to kill me or something?” she giggled as arms locked around her waist.

“Uuu, did the little baby get a boo, boo, here let me kiss it better”

“What?! Noooo, that’s disgusting!” she whined, trying to push off with her feet but how in the hell was she this strong! Catra could barely keep her face away with both hands in the mix!

“Help! Adora she’s being unfair!”

Adora snorted before flying towards them both in Catra’s horror “ARH!” they were laughing so hard at this point. It was a miracle no guard patrol had stopped them as they lay there in a puddle, wiping their tears away while sighing in relief at this little free time they’d been blessed with.

“Ah, we’re here” Adora said, brows rising as she blinked above Catra, strands of dirty blond hair sticking to her forehead with a stupidly fond smile.

“Then you can get, off!”

“UGHF” Catra extended her arms, panting before rolling off Scarlet and putting a hand on her beating chest.

Why do I keep getting squished in-between them!? And why is my chest so.. .. It might've been the recovery stim but even when she took it Catra didn't feel as energized as when her hair was brushed or just now... Normally she'd feel light, and tingly like spiders tippy toeing in her stomach... Keeping her head low warmth surged to her face while following the two inside, quickly looking away when the blond glanced her way with a big grin as Scarlet fell back beside her taking her hand.

Adora's fist hovered over the door when Scarlet shook her head pointing at the handle while the two of them pressed their backs to the wall beside her and the second door coming after the empty reception. They'd been let out so late only the first night shifts were working unless there were other special sessions going on like theirs had. And they might've napped just a little....

"Who- Adora right, you're one of Weaver's students, correct? How can I help you?" a man with glasses, clawed hands and silvery fur on his chins and forearms almost cheerily asked even though it looked like he was packing up his satchel.

Of course , Catra said in her head while peaking past the doorframe while almost climbing over Scarlet who sat on one knee trying to keep them both low. All the adults always adored Adora..... Catering to her, giving favors, praising her, giving her pointers and overall favors. But Catra supposed they might've been trying to stay on Weaver's good side or curry favor with an up and comer..... Still, it was always her...

“Yes sir, it’s my squad and I, we have an upcoming challenge against another commander cadet squadron, and we’ve just come from the one weeklong interrogation test....” Adora trailed off while pulling on the root of her ponytail.

“You lasted the entire week? Impressive, then I’m guessing you're on a recovery stim right now, you should really be resting” he said with a concerned look.

“Yes sir... I know sir but-”

“The mess hall is closed; I’ll go get a few emergency kits, how many where there in your group?”

“Ah... F-five" he nodded before stepping through a back door into what looked like from here.... A larger supply closet racked with small bottles, boxes and bandages?

“Now!” Catra skidded over Scarlet’s shoulders by swinging her legs around in a ninety-degree angle smacking her face with her hips “Cat I’m not your fucking springboard” she whispers annoyedly, only to receive a mischiefs grin from the feline “but aren’t you always so strong? What could little me do to you?” she purred, tail swaying in an S motion. *That’s what boasting gets yah* , the brunet snickered.

“It’s about principle”

“Mhmm”

“Guys you need to leave before he comes back! What are you even doing?!” Adora bit out while Catra snagged a few stims, some solutions to drink and a couple of blood bags.

“Done” Scarlet said just as the door handle turned.

Bolting Catra bumped the freezer door shutting it with her hip, but in her stride one of the red bags slipped under her arm “shit!”

“Just go!” Adora whisper shouts, taking a step to the side, feet together completely blocking it as Catra slid through the door immediately getting pulled to the side.

“What happened?!”

“I dropped one!?”

“Idio- HOW???”

“There you go, take some time to recover, the stimuli help but they also give you false energy, if you don’t want to feel like, well

shit tomorrow I recommend sleeping properly" the doctor explained, handing over five small boxes to the blond who bowed.

"Yes, thank you si-ir, aaah!" Adora saluted with one of her undoubtedly big toothy stupid smiles as a box slipped off the other "ah sorry sir, let me just, get, that" the blond kneeled looking them both straight in the eye, snatching the blood bag in one quick motion with the box.

"I think she's mad" Scarlet whispered making Catra's ears fall "she won't be for long, right? We got those energy bars that actually taste really good"

Scarlet sighed indicatively as red and white boots stepped through the doorway "thanks again!" Adora said pointing towards the door with two fingers and narrowed eyes.

Heads held low they followed, Adora always got- "what were you thinking?! Stealing from the infirmary!?! What if we got caught??? Or what if someone else needed these!"

"But we didn't, and we need these, I'm not kidding, it's been a week of almost nothing, besides you asked for five when there's three of us"

"That's completely different! This was reckless and Ires-"

“Adora” Scarlet butted in grabbing the Blond's shoulder “we’re fine, no one got caught and you also need the energy, come on its ok”

Adora pouted and huffed as a string of hair fell down on her forehead “I just don’t want Weaver to know.... I don’t like seeing you guys like that..... You get so weird...” if Weaver found out they stole supplies.... Catra didn’t want to finish that thought but... Flashes of red and darkness as her limbs locked and gray spindly fingers extended towards her while she could do, nothing still came, intrusively wiggling into her mind.....

“We’ll be fine Dora....” Scarlet said while very softly brushing her cheek and pressing their foreheads together.

The blond visibly relaxed, shoulders falling as she let out a deep sigh “you promise?” Adora asked sounding so small suddenly...

“Yeah, I promise” Scarlet murmured back.

Catra hugged herself, even though they both went through the same thing with Weaver her reaction was almost radically different. Maybe it was because she’d known her parents, maybe she just didn’t feel anything else towards the witch other than hate at this point but unlike Catra herself.... She seemed closer to them both after a small period of hiding away from them.... When Catra.... It both hurt and felt so warm to be close to Adora.....

Like being by the forge, it could easily burn you yet on a cold day there was nowhere else you wanted to be.....

Sighing, she ducked under the two, squeezing through while caressing the undersides of their jaws by softly headbutting them "no one's going to tell, and I doubt we're the only ones who've had this idea"

"Uhhh.... Your probably right-"

A sharp whistle echoed, Catra's head snapping back with a hiss and ears folded "who the fu-"

"That's what we should be asking, we just came from the doc's office, and you know what he told us?" a burly voice said belonging to a yellow eyed pupilless..... Was this guy the same species as Grizzlor? Only instead of brown mane-like hair, his was black without the beard.

"Buddy, we don't really care....." Scarlet drawled making Catra giggle at the other groups expressions while Adora rolled her eyes at the vampire for escalating no doubt.

"Golden child, you should get your guard dog under control before this becomes unsalvageable for you, because you know who we ran into? The doc just packed up telling us he can't reopen, and we'd might have to wait till morning" the Grizzlor lookalike said as a red lizard man hissed like a snake, the fin like protrusions on the back of his? Its thick head flapping up and down rapidly.

“That’s not our problem? How is this our problem???” Catra whispered in between the two girls while glancing at the other group as the corner of her mouth rose.

“Shut up runt, no one cares about your opinion, everyone knows your just a leach with no pull here” the three Etherian humans glared daggers at the feline which professionally wasn’t the best move, but totally what Catra was going for even if it made a fiery anger flare like a pressure around her head as Adora and Scarlet both took a decisive step forward, startling the three.

“Guys, we could just shar-”

“No Adora, this is ours; And they won’t just ask for a little, I know you know this” Scarlet cut her off, dropping the energy bar packets behind them before cracking her knuckles.

“These idiots are already looking down on us, do you really want to give our stuff to them?”

Adora gave Catra a frustrated sigh while dropping boxes of emergency rations before tightening her hair band “shit! No Catra but this is against protocol” giggling the felines claws unsheathed like obsidian knives while shoulder bumping the frowning blond.

“That hasn’t stopped you before, now has it ~ mmmm? The golden child is really a bad girl” Catra squeakily cackled as Adora’s rosy cheeks seemingly heat up even more.

“I can’t believe she swore” Scarlet chuckled while giving Adora a sideway glancing smirk.

“Ah! Fuck you, I swear!”

“Ok, miss yes sir, no sir-”

“Enough! I will not be disrespected like this!” the pupilless guy roared showing rows of sharp teeth which looked thick enough to easily crush bone.

Adora met him head on, his wide swing almost harmlessly skidding off the Blond's forearm and bicep as she leaned to the side before landing a hard THUD in-between the side of his ribs. Gurgling on his own spit he brought down his other massive arm but even with their size difference Catra knew Adora had drilled into herself the entirety of the Hordes main CQC style. Knowing every move without even having to think about it which made a person only relying on their innate strength.... A moderate warm up.

Again, the blond didn’t take it completely head on, skidding it off her arm and shoulder before stepping to the right. Five heavy yet lightning-fast punches landed on the same side she’d just jammed

two knuckles into. His eyes bulging out of their sockets the lowered arm was swung with a blind raged growl, saliva flying over Adora and splashing into the wall.

"Gotcha" arm under her bicep Adora put a foot in front of his before putting all her weight on his back.

Face first he landed on the floor, arm behind his back one twitch away from being snapped the wrong way he screamed "what ARE YOU WAITING FOR, GET THEM!"

"Our turn" Catra grinned fangs already wetted from excitement by her tongue.

Adora jumped back as a haymaker cut through the air just before Scarlet's foot lodged itself in the Etherian's gut. Though she didn't get to revel in her small victory for long as a red blur flew right into her chest "OUGH!" she grunted before grabbing the red lizard's arms who hissed at Scarlet before its jaws snapped at the air where the body part it'd been aiming for had been. Growling back the vampire craned her head before slamming it down into the top of its skull, forcing its jaws to clamp shut.

"Don't hesitate Adora! It's three versus five!" Scarlet almost roared out before wrestling the lizard to the ground and hammering her fist into his snout, teeth clattering to the floor.

Catra in the meanwhile sprinted towards the big guy, springing off the ground before landing feet first into his confused face as his friend pointed at her. The blond quickly elbowed the confused girl, crimson splattering the wounded girl's face. Landing Catra took advantage, dropping to all fours and sweeping her legs right from under her.

The feline grinned at the focused looking blond standing up straigh- "watch out!" Catra's head snapped to the side taking one on the chin as Adora was quickly forced on the defensive when the other group's leader just shot up, punching center mass right into the Blonds' raised arms.

Adora's feet lifted off the ground but getting back down she weaved aiming to hit him under the chin as someone tackled her side. Catra panicked but two idiots were now blocking her path "looks like we got the easy one"

"Let's just kick her teeth in and help Grador" they were looking down on her, they always did even when her reputation was so volatile.....

Catra seethed, throughout the years people, especially if she wasn't with Adora and sometimes even with Scarlet thought she was such easy pickings. It wouldn't be unheard of for other cadets to try and corner her, always in small groups, laughing at her, insulting or making fun of her and even trying to pull her tail.... Thinking her reactions were funny.... Even though many had lost a finger or an eye for it. Still, they regarded her as the weak one, just attaching herself to people better than herself. Saying she could kiss up to them and they'd treat her as their little **PET** ! BECASUE SHE WAS ALREADY SUCH A LAPCAT?!?

Dropping to all fours she dashed, the two falling into stances immediately, one leg forward as Catra sprung off the floor spinning midair claws extended. The two Etherian’s recoiled as blood gushed out of their arms, red hot lines now tearing through their sleeves. Landing on her feet Catra immediately changed direction, toe claws sparking on the steel floor as she kept her momentum, circling around the other kid and using him to block the others' vision.

Ferociously she aimed for the hand trying to grab her. Nails digging in, the tips of two fingers went flying making his eyes go wide as these empty spaces undoubtedly burned. But now was not the time to get distracted as Catra tore open his side, forcing him to fall to his knees and cover the wound....

In a flash of frustrated anger Catra didn’t spare even a second on him before charging again, arm raised only for a hot white flash to make her recoil. *A knife?!* She growled internally, betting they’d have used it to force them to give everything up, the image of a blade at either of those two’s throats, even if they’d never go through with-it blood surged to her head making her almost see nothing but red.

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Scarlet watched the blond elbow the girl that’d tackled her while strangling the red lizard whose claws were lodged into her arm and stomach muscles. Her eyes hadn’t changed, body staying relatively normal, which was why this’d been more trouble than it was worth and even if she knew Adora could fight.... It just made her skin crawl to watch. And then there was this fucker who just wouldn’t pass out, only staring at her with a bleeding mouth and missing teeth.

“I have more important people to take care of you piece of trash!” lifting up his head she slammed it back down, the back of it crashing and echoing off the steel floor with a BAM.

Her front teeth burned, and her eyes wanted to change.... Entire body now on fire after a week of enduring and all she wanted was to get back to their bunks and lay down while talking about nothing at all..... *Yet these worthless..* .. The crimson liquid bleeding from everyone's wounds was making her head spin, vision flicker between normal and this void of a world with only outlines and rivers of light, pumping inside of every being.....

Scarlet slapped herself, hard, she was going off again, she shouldn’t let that writhing feeling consume her like this... *That’s just the bad part talking, I’m the one in control* she thought, exhaling and spinning on her heel. Adora had backpedaled looking slightly worse for wear, ducking and weaving the big darkly furred arms, getting him on the chin only to get flailed in the back. He just wasn’t going down.

“You bitch!” the girl yelled, again getting back on her feet after getting kicked in the shin, only this time an iron grip on her shoulder made her stumble.

Fear, that was what Scarlet saw in her eyes as her head leaned back, mouth trembling “w-wai-” thrown to the ground a foot stomped down a heavy bang echoing through the hallway. Another one down.

Foot getting stuck on some hair, Scarlet wiped some crimson off her shoe that'd been tainted by the now pooling head. They were near the infirmary anyway; the night shift would come here soon and sweep them up, not that she found herself caring. Yet as the blond again caught her opponent's arm, this time twisting it back with an elbow to his spine, something popped. Scarlet found a smile on her face warmly forming as Adora dislocated his arm.

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"Phew, he was tenacious. You guy-" Adora wiped her forehead, flinching at the small cut when her face was muffled into the red eyed girls chest.

"You, ok? Adora you're bleeding, Cat! We need to- CATRA, you should've stayed closer look at you, we got an emergency kit here don't we!?" Scarlet almost yelled while turning Adora's head in different directions with a worried expression.

"Scar I'm fine-"

"Yeah, it's mostly theirs anyway, hehe, we fucked, em, up"

"But your hurt...." the antsy girl said still holding her head in a tight lock, the only plus here being no one could see the heat surging up her neck.... Why that even happened Adora didn't know, but it wasn't unpleasant... Actually, kinda nice the way she held her cheeks, Adora almost daydreamed as the familiar sound of Catra tiptoeing behind her stopped.

“Come on, you should be happier, we won! A few scrapes are just our medals” Catra gloated but Adora saw Scarlet’s eyes only scanning over both their cuts while pouting...

“Yeah, yeah... You're both letting me check on you once we’re back at the bunks” Adora glanced to Catra who glanced at her, both knowing there wasn’t really any arguing when she got like this...

The track back was uneventful, just the whirring of air traveling through the pipes and occasional bot or guard stomping around in the distance. Catra kept reciting what’d just happened excitedly in her usual fashion with sound effects and an overdramatic play which made it sound like someone had actually died. Adora just grinned letting her go on, but teasing her just a little over the fact that she took out the bigger opponent. Catra scoffed saying, she could’ve handled him no problem even faster than her “oh yeah, sureeee” Adora quipped while glancing at Scarlet who simply shrugged before murmuring something on the lines “if Weaver wasn’t such a bastard, I could’ve handled them...”

Adora didn’t comment on Scarlet’s remark, the dark-haired girl having become very quick to shut down the smallest thing she’d used to say about her adoptive mother. But Weaver was trying to push them to become better, to become force captains and then bring order to Etheria. It wasn’t a small task, but it was their duty for the betterment of everyone. Weaver was hard on them, but everything she did had a reason behind it. Catra always got frustrated at the slightest mention of Weaver trying to teach or help while Scarlet openly argued against her.

It made her body feel heavy, she hated it when they were punished even if in her mind it wasn't their fault. Seeing them limp back to the bunks made her blood run cold as hopelessness seeped into every crevasse of her body, knowing by their expressions they wouldn't even try to improve training scores or study harder for any tests. She tried and tried to up her training, getting perfect marks, compensating for any shortcomings in her squad, planning for any and all scenarios..... Everything was usually under control.... Yet Adora's chest tightened, and bile rose high enough for her to want to gag, forcing her jaws to clamp shut. Momentarily she had to close her eyes as the world felt uneasy, feet suddenly feeling wobbly.

"Adora? Does it hurt somewhere? What's going on?" Scarlet asked, grabbing her shoulder, eyes scanning her up and down again.

"I'm fine, just a little dizzy, hehe...." Adora regretted her answer immediately as Scarlet's frown said volumes.

"Your pale as a ghost, telling me your fine? Come on, lean on me"

"It's seriously fine, noth-"

"Did you hit your head again? You need to watch that, you're already working with a limited number of braincells- *ow!*"

“If you're so energetic, carry this” Scarlet glared, pushing both of their stuff into the feline's arms.

“Hey! I can still- w-wha?!” suddenly Adora’s feet weren’t touching the ground anymore and she found herself hanging off Scarlet’s neck, pushed completely into her embrace.

“I can walk! Scar!” Adora whined but only receiving a glance in return her brows furrowed as Catra snickered beside them with a very telling look.

“Not so fun now, is it? Dora”

“Mmmmm.....” the blond grumbled while being hoisted up and pushed somehow even closer to the almost completely black-haired girl.

As they turned Adora recognized the hall they were in and seeing Catra hop forward towards what was undoubtedly a door console blood rushed to her head “come on let me down, I can walk to the bunk, pleeeease” she’d never hear the end of it if the others saw her like this!

But it was already too late, the doors swishing open, and Scarlet stepped through without a care in the world and all she could do was hide her face in her palms.... She could practically hear the looks being given to her as they passed over to their bunks...

“They let you out this late? Without patching you up? Jeez I guess being Weavers favorites gives you more trouble than it’s worth” Lonnie commented while slapping a card down on the bed some of the cadets were using as a table.

“You have no idea.....” Scarlet murmured while gently setting Adora down in a sitting position before immediately curling up the hem of her shirt and hissing softly “ahh.... Someone get me a first aid kit, now”

“On it” Kyles hand shot up while jumping off the card game bed.

“Nope, Lonnie, Lonnie, Lonnie, we ran into that guy looking like Grizzlor and his *friends*” Catra gloated again, setting their new supplies down on Scarlet’s bed “and beat the absolute shit out of them”

“Here” Kyle said, glancing behind Scarlet “oh wow, how did you get all this?”

“You actually beat them? And stole their stuff? Wow, never expected that, especially from-”

“Adora convinced the doc, they tried to steal from us” Scarlet explained making Lonnie hum.

“Agh, Catra, could you?” Adora asked, eyes darting to the supplies and then to the others.

“B-but-”

“Cat, please?” she pushed as Scarlet kicked the cooling vents lid making it clatter to the floor before grabbing a rectangular slab of steel from inside.

“And then you're sitting your ass down right here” the vampire pointed right beside Adora who almost jumped, shivering at the ice-cold piece of metal pushed into an almost purple mark by her ribs.

“Fine, but I’m not-”

“Cat.....” the red eyed girls eyes narrowed making Catra’s ears fall as she stomped over to the others.

“URGH! Fine... Your so demanding.... Here you idiots, spoils of war, even if you didn’t do anything....”

“Oh shit, really? Umm, thanks” Adora could see Catra rolling her eyes even if she wasn’t facing her, but this helped get the others to like Cat more, even with her prickly nature.

Adora tried to smile but her entire face scrunched up as Scarlet cleaned a few cuts on her stomach, the alcohol coated cotton stinging and making her toned stomach muscles constrict even with how lightly she was doing it. Soon she taped a cover over the cuts before lifting her shirt up even more and tsking at another bruise she found as the mattress sank as little as it could beside Adora.

“Press this to your face while you wait” Scarlet murmured while handing Catra another slab.

Just sitting there Adora played with the sheet in between her fingers, waiting and trying not to focus on Scarlet sitting in front of her, closely inspecting her before grabbing her bouncing knee “does it hurt anywhere else?”

“Ah, n-no"

“Hmm? Catra, could you check her back?” the blonds head snapped to the side as Catra was already leaning backwards “a couple of tears here” she said making the grip on her knee tighten.

“Don’t try to play strong now, it won’t work on your cuts dumb, dumb”

Adora’s lips pursed before sighing “but it doesn't hurt”

“Still has to be looked at”

“Then what about you? Your shirts torn-”

“You know I heal”

“Not always” Catra retorted.

<<<<<<

Scarlet stuttered in her movement while climbing onto the bed and pulling up the back of Adora’s shirt, but there was no way they noticed that and Catra wouldn’t pounce or disturb her while she took care of the Blond's wounds..... Drinking one blood bag would be enough to start the-

“You're such a liar! Your still bleeding, a lot!” Catra gawked as clawed hands grabbed her shirt.

“Wha-”

“Stay still, I’m almost done”

“No, I just heard something-”

“Just give me a sec” Scarlet tried, maybe she could still run, the door would need a code at this hour, the bathroom was just a dead end.....

“Don’t even think about it” Catra whispered, narrowing her eyes “oops, hehe, didn’t notice” Scarlet winked while finishing Adora’s band aid before quickly finding herself surrounded on both sides.

One angry cat girl pulled up the hem of her shirt while the other locked down her legs “nooo..... What are you doing???”

“Don’t even try playing innocent now..... Sit” Adora said in a low authoritative tone as Scarlet tried to cover the gashes on her torso and arm demurely.

The next ten minutes consisted of her whining that she’d heal and to just give her both bags, that they didn’t need to do this..... But did they listen? No....

“You're such a hypocrite” Catra said slapping the tape on her bandage “ow! Can’t you be any gentler??”

“Not when you're such a big fat liar”

“Come on, we’ve hurt her pride enough Cat, and it’s your turn” Catra grumbled at that but at least Scarlet got to enact her revenge for that one.....

After a long while they decided to take their second recovery stims in the morning while Scarlet emptied both blood bags now, considering they didn’t have a freezer and all. It was like honey to her after a week of nothing but shitty ration bars and a cold room. With that, after treating each other's wounds the trio just sat there, legs crossed simply murmuring about the stupidest things before laying down, side by side.

In silence they laid there until the lights turned off, and even then, while the others returned to their bunks after the week they’d had, none moved. Catra shuffled in between them but didn’t get up as they wondered if this was ok. Turning to her side, Scarlet’s mouth opened and closed but she wasn’t sure what to say. Hugging like she did with her mom and dad was seemingly frowned upon, and Scarlet could count on one hand how many times she’d seen anyone else be close. If she searched for it, Scarlet might’ve seen some give each other looks for just a little too long or small touches like the three of them did.

Lonnie wouldn’t talk and neither would the ones left in their squad. It was a silent agreement born from them living together for so long, no tattling, in the same way you do not steal from your squad mates. Scarlet considered the others here close; she’d defend them and make sure they were fine, but her priorities had quickly become these two who were kind of looking at her....

Blue and yellow eyes lightly glowed in the dark following the hand brushing up against hers. Catra didn’t flinch away or do much of anything else than stare into her eyes and Scarlet swore she could hear Catra’s heart thudding against her ribcage or maybe it was

her own. Shuffling slightly Scarlet’s other arm went under her pillow but extended to the Blond's shoulder.

Adora turned to face her properly now with a warm smile giving her the courage to brush her now free hair off her forehead. They never really talked about anything like this, the words now even to Scarlet seeming completely foreign when she faintly still remembered her former life, now eight years behind her.

Dad and mom hugged her every day, and now..... Scarlet felt like she’d taken that for granted, meanwhile Catra and Adora never had that.... Only Weaver..... And each other, completely terrified of giving an actual hug. And now Scarlet was too after living here for so long. The contrast was so large to her former life, *ICK!*

Scarlet almost made a noise as Catra shuffled closer into her open arms, Adora blinking behind her but also moving. Arm hooking around Catra’s back Scarlet waited for her to shuffle closer, she didn’t want to scare or push either of them into something they didn’t want. But still Catra’s head slotted under Scarlet’s jaw. She squeezed around the feline's waist as another hand mimicked hers, Adora pressing into Catra’s back making a shiver run through her. No one said anything, just breathing slowly while their legs entangled.

There was no way Catra couldn’t feel her heartbeat, but Scarlet didn’t care, just pressing her forehead into Adora’s. The blond slowly blinked, eyelids falling further each time, their fingers twitching as they accidentally caressed each other, Scarlet’s eyes bouncing between those two oceans of blue. Adora’s pushed against hers, slinking in between as Scarlet did the same-

Phrrrrrrr.....

Both glanced down in surprise only to notice Catra had already fallen asleep, a low rumbling purr now reverberating from her chest, vibrating on both of them. Scarlet doubted they'd ever talk about this in the fear Catra would shirk away if they ever had another opportunity like this. So instead, they both hugged tighter, letting it sooth them to a deep, deep slumber while enjoying each other's entangled presence.

Unjust

Chapter Summary

Shadow Weaver has returned and she's called the trio to the Black Garnet room for some reason a couple hours before their match against another cadet squadron.

What does she want? And why is Scarlet so angry?

Chapter Notes

I was going to do a quick summary in the end notes of Fang's, Claw's and a girl with a Sword but I pressed the end notes by accident, which hides it and it was all gone..... 5000k characters gone..... I'm just gonna go to sleep now.....

Enjoy.

Unjust

The Fright Zone, 10 years before Thaymor

Catra's little legs and arms pumped as she raced down the hall, tongue out and panting. Eyes darting back, she saw only an empty hallway making a small grin form. After the next intersection she was gone, those stupid idiots were too lazy to go any further and Catra could just lay low for a whi-

AGH!!!

"Stupid fucking kid, you're getting overconfident!" a man clad in full Horde armor almost roared out, boot slamming into the felines

now lurching stomach.

Back hitting the wall all air shot out of her constricting lungs, sending her into a gasping coughing fit as heavy boots stomped over from two different directions “trying to sneak outside again? I don’t know which is more surprising, that this little shit keeps trying or that we actually returned home with creatures like her”

“Dude, its standard protocol to capture and collect all assets and resources, besides you're like the only one I’ve seen to have such a hate boner for, whatever she is”

Ears ringing, she pushed herself off the floor, shakily getting onto all fours, vision blurred from the tears brimming in her eyes “I’m guessing you weren’t in Halfmoon, fuck.... Those ferocious bastards, you couldn’t trust your eyes or ears and those beasts..... For Hordak’s honor.... And now there’s this god damn eyesore.....” he bit out, sounding wavy and angulating in Catra’s ears.

“Of course I wasn’t, I just graduated and that was over five years ago, those guys are all veterans by now. which makes me question, why are you still here? Shouldn’t you be on the front with the others?” the guard who had kicked Catra looked away murmuring something under his breath as she stood on unsteady feet, glaring at them before her hand flew to her mouth.

Knees hitting the floor vomit spewed as her throat burned and cheeks bloated “ugh, really?”

“Hey, isn’t this one of Weavers wards? We probably should keep our disciplinary lesson short”

“Yeah, yeah, but this one just doesn’t learn where she can and can’t go, so next time I catch you, I don’t care if you’re eight, I’m leaving you in the basement with the other rule breakers for a night, see if you're this rebellious after that. Now, you should clean up your mess, oh, look there's a rag right there”

“ARGHH!” Catra screamed throatily as the soldier grabbed a fist full of hair-

Vision sharpening, she flailed, claws sinking through the steel plate on his arm while he yelped, instantly letting go and covering the red gashes “fucking bitch, never fucking mind I guess that days today, I promise you’ll regret doing that!”

Groaning on the floor, Catra’s eyes darted up as a shadow covered her features. The underside of a boot stared her in the face. Eyelids scrunched shut Catra flinched away as time slowed, s-she was so stupid! And now her face was going to be used to clean her own vomit off the floor... It made her shiver in rage, this was so unfair, the rules were so stupid she just wanted to quickly pop out into the yard and get something.....

Tears stung at the corners of her eyes, and yet through paralyzing fear blond hair and blue eyes comforted her. A tooth gapped smile filling her with warmth, *it doesn't matter what they do to us, I*

look out for you, and you look out for me, nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other .

Trembling she steeled herse- "you leave her alone!" familiar blond hair swayed in a ponytail before her eyes.

The man stumbled back on one foot, crashing on his behind as Adora slammed into his side "who the fu- *AAARGH*" the other guard cried out and Catra's gaze quickly snapped to him.

A dark-haired girl hung from his arm, growling as a dark red color dampened his sleeve "get OFF! BASTARD!" Scarlet kicked off landing in front of the feline as Adora rolled back.

"Stop picking on Catra! Guards shouldn't be acting like such meanies!" Adora's chest puffed out as she grimaced, arms out on both sides, standing in front of them like a shield.

"Shit, do you know what you fucks have done?? Now you all will need disciplinary action, come on le-"

"Ah what..... Dude it's Weavers golden child a-and her guard dog and their pet... Tread carefully unless you want to end up like a scrunched up dry ration bar. Fuck why can't I stop shaking....." the guard which'd been bitten clutched the base of his trembling forearm as crimson droplets spilled to the ground.

“If you don’t leave, I’m telling Weaver you tried to hit Adora!” Scarlet said stepping forward as the guard holding his arm leaned up against the wall “let's just go.... I think I need to go see a medic.... It hurts so fucking much....”

“It was just a scratch, how can.....” the second guard turned to the trio scanning Scarlet before his fists relaxed and he turned around grabbing his partner.

“That’s what I thought...” Scarlet spat out, sleeve pressed to her mouth as her eyes dimmed and the inky black on the whites slunk away into the back of her eyelids.

“Are you ok?” the blond asked softly, rubbing her back while Catra wrapped her arms around her stomach.

“My tummy hurts *blegh...* I think my ribs broken...” she sniffled as another hand squeezed her shoulder tenderly.

“Here, I’ll wipe that off” Scarlet said, pulling out a crumpled napkin, gently pushing her cheek and brushing around her mouth “there”

“Can I feel?” Adora asked, pointing to her stomach.

Catra nodded, shaky arms loosening as the blond slipped a hand under her shirt. Whimpering Catra made a displeased noise as

Adora felt around, pushing just a little on the bone while her eyebrows knitted together in concentration.

“I don’t feel any breaks, I think you're ok on that part, but let's get you to the infirmary, you think you can walk?” wobbly legs strained as Catra pushed herself up, only for a sharp pain to shoot around her tummy.

“Mmmh.....” she squeaked.

“It’s ok, hop on” Scarlet kneeled with her arms out behind her.

“I’ll help” Adora added while setting her hands on Catra’s sides.

Letting out a small yelp she climbed onto Scarlet’s back, grabbing her shoulders while laying onto its curve as she was hoisted up by her legs. The blond pushed from behind, palm circling her back soothingly making Catra’s tail wrap around her hand.

“H-how did you even find me?” she huffed.

“Hmm? Lonnie said she saw you running to west wing, so we thought you tried sneaking outside again”

“Oh” Catra muttered when Adora’s hands disappeared making her grasp onto Scarlet with a squeak “I’m gonna fall!”

“I gotch yah, my arms are like steel, no way I would drop someone as light as you, hehe” Scarlet giggled, peaking over her shoulder as Catra tried to bury her face into her back.

“I think you dropped something” Adora said, Catra’s heart stuttering in panic.

“W-wai-”

“Did you make this?” she asked, holding a round rock up towards a ceiling lamp.

“Y-yeah, so what? You can just throw it away....”

“Huh? Why? It’s pretty hehehe, and funny” blinking something fluttered in Catra’s chest as Adora giggled with wide eyes awing.

“Then you can keep it... If you want” she murmured into Scarlet’s back.

“Really! Thank you, I’ll use it as a paper weight”

“Can I see?” Adora hopped over, holding the rock Catra’d carved her own face onto, showing her tongue with a grin in her cupped palms.

“It’s beautiful, you're really good with your claws” Scarlet said with a big smile painted across her face making Catra try to nuzzle and hide her face even more into the back of her neck.

“Well! I didn’t make one for you, and don’t expect one.....” her voice cracked as her face heated up and hair stood.

“Umm? I know, you clearly made it for Adora, because you like her!”

“I don’t! Just throw it away!”

“Nuh uh, you went through all that trouble to get it, so I’m keeping it”

Catra hated the fact Scarlet, during one year, had picked up on Adora’s stupid habits while it felt like she wasn’t even fazed anymore or even annoyed when she tried pushing her away..... No at some point she’d started brushing it off while grinning at her and making a joke out of it or something.... And now here she was with Adora carrying her and defending her....

“Comfy up there?” Catra’s brows rose but she nodded into Scarlet’s ponytail and neck “yeah.....” she purred very lightly into the middle of her warm back, curled up with half lidded eyes.

Scarlet didn’t turn but lifted her up a little higher while whispering “good, take us with you next time, please? We can look for rocks together”

“Ok....” Catra muttered, very slightly hooking her jaw over Scarlet’s shoulder, cheek barely caressing the vampire's now slightly pinkish ear.

“Hehe” Catra’s eyes glanced to the side where the mischiefs giggle had come from only to show a proudly and widely extremely smugly smirking Adora staring at her.

“W-what? I-I still don’t like her or anything!”

“I didn’t say anything” the dumb blond shrugged, eyes glinting with that smirk never faltering.

The Fright Zone, Black Garnet room, early morning,
2 years and 1 month before Thaymor

Scarlet, Adora and Catra stood stiffly, arms behind their backs as a dim red glow highlighted half their scuffed-up faces. Scarlet’s chin pointed forward with her half-lidded eyes as Catra’s head tilted to

the side a band aid on her cheek, and expression pointed down in contrast to Adora’s whose was held high. Expressive blue eyes leaned towards being gray as she stared straight forward, a band aid over her tensed brow, posture perfect and shoulders up unlike the two others which drooped.....

From the corner of her eye Scarlet saw a black oval cauldron, the green and black surface bubbling almost maliciously. But as she focused on it a picture formed. Dusty flat dirt land spread to all sides by the same-colored beech castle walls? Or a colosseum, people sitting cheered, mouths open mutedly to her in the stand's hands in the air as an armored individual crashed to the ground helmet rolling to the side. It revealed this, maybe a couple years younger girl than herself. Blond with bright dark green piercing eyes and ashen gray tips to the ends of her hairs. She must’ve growled with the way she was gritting her teeth before picking up her sword and charging someone. Both clad in shackles, around their arms, ankles and necks. Scarlet stared with mild curiosity, wondering what this was as someone snapped their fingers, the picture turning back into a bubbling swirl of green shadowy black soup.

A maroon robed, masked woman stalked around the tall red crystal suddenly as the shadows around them angulated, some forming like almost invisible talons tracing around Scarlet and Catra, both flanking Adora on each side... Weaver had been quiet, like a disappointed mother seeing if any of her kids would fess up. It put a disgusting taste on Scarlet’s tongue as she held in a grimace, *you're not my mom and you never will be... Hell, you shouldn’t be anyone's parent.....* . Scarlet bit her tongue while dull nails dug into her arms as pictures of Weaver cutting into a corps, a woman with her wide re-

“Why is it that when I return, the first thing I hear is you’ve brutalized members of the squad you're going up against today, to an extent that mages had to be involved”

“Psht, drama queens, they started it and then tattle-”

“Catra” Weaver loomed over the feline who froze, eyes transfixed on that mask “speak when spoken to, is that clear?” Catra gave a small nod before her eyes fell to the ground again “good, I can’t believe you still don’t know proper etiquette, but maybe that’s too much for a slacker like you”

“They attacked us, we defended ourselves-”

“That is not what I’ve been told cadet-” the witch hovered over in an instant, lowering her masked face to Scarlet’s level.

Tensing, Scarlet felt that familiar cold worming its way in as her body slightly trembled with a sickening feeling, that icy fear seeping into her bones. She couldn’t move, again under Shadow Weavers form, feeling isolated, hollow.... Also, a reminder of how empty she was, like all power had been sapped not only because of Weaver... But hunger creeping in. Shame washed over Scarlet, this was pathetic, weak and deplorable yet here she was cowering away like she was seven again, hiding away in that tree trunk as Brightmoon soldiers decapitated her dad, kicking his body and spitting on the ground he laid on...

Red hot rage poured into her veins as she mimicked the witch, scowling while hissing out the next words through her teeth "well I'm telling you otherwise, read my lips, I did as you wanted, Catra told you the truth and they lied to your face, what are you going to do about that? Now if that's all, we have class, ma'am" Scarlet put a foot forward, only for her muscles not to budge as an electric buzz reverberated around her.

"Then what were you doing around the medical wing at that time?"

"Taking a walk after not being able to for a week? What does it matter?" Catra asked precariously while side eyeing her locked, now red and static form. Completely unable to even move her jaw.

"I told you to be quiet cadet, seems my absence has bread unruliness in the two of you and I will not have that behavior affect Adora's future. Now, Adora ~ tell me the truth, why were you there and why would you risk getting disqualified to start such a dispute, I had to convince the other instructors on your behalf so you could still participate, do you know how much trouble you three have caused me?"

Yeah right , Scarlet scoffed in her mind, *like you'd ever let Adora be held behind or miss an opportunity...* . Not many would dare say no to Weaver when she even asked for people to, *reconsider* their verdicts or grievances. There wasn't much of a choice there...

“We weren’t feeling well even after the first stim, so as we were just yesterday informed of a match, we decided to quickly get a second stim to insure maximum performance the next day. We then engaged in combat without knowing who our opponents were as they were being hostile towards us and wouldn’t let us leave, ma’am” Adora reported to Weaver's humming, almost soft response.

“I see, that is worrying to hear, Catra must have egged them on for them not to listen to reason, how unfortunate, I’m guessing you also didn’t even try to defuse the situation?” Weaver turned, arms behind her back to condescendingly cock her head to the side towards the vampire who could only glare back.

“How disappointing-”

“That’s not what happened! Weaver, I tried to tell them to back off, but they just wouldn’t, none of us wanted this to happen, it wasn’t their fault it was mine for not being able to-”

“Adora..... I know you want to defend the people under you, but you don’t need to lie to me, you forget I’ve been here too for all these years, and I know how these two are, you will be dismissed for now, I will evaluate if a punishment is needed after the match” she said brushing the blonds cheek with gray pointy fingers.

Shakily Scarlet’s head turned as her body strained against Weaver's grip “now go, make me and the Horde proud”

“Yes, miss Weaver” Adora saluted, stuttering in her step towards the door “umm, what about Scar? Why are you still-”

“We have something to discuss, but if you must know she broke one of our rules by transforming”

“S-she didn-”

“She didn’t! Shadow Weaver we were there, not once did she use that I swear!” Adora yelled, cutting Catra off with an extended arm almost like she was shielding the feline.

“I know your upset, but you will address me calmly and with integrity, even with your skills there is no possibility for you three to have defeated eight people, as such I do believe they instigated your encounter but not as you where”

Catra sputtered forward but Adora blocked her way with an arm in front of her midsection “bullshit they were five! We wouldn’t have stayed if they were that many!”

“Adora, contain her or I will, everything will come to light so do not worry, we will only have a short talk, now leave” Shadow Weaver stated with finality.

Body having snapped back into a straight posture Scarlet could only stare with shaking red eyes into Adora’s now depressingly

gray and almost mortified expression. *Just, go* , she mouthed with a trembling jaw, *take, Catra, before-* Adora's gaze fell but she turned on her heel ushering the feline out who almost stumbled back while holding onto the Blonds' shoulders.

"Yes Weaver" Adora droned, pulling the stuttering feline outside as the door hydraulics churned shut.

"Now, how should we deal with you? Not only did you threaten to break free during your weeklong test almost failing Adora in the process, but then you decide it'd be a good idea exposing what you are to a bunch of young cadets, what do you have to say for yourself" Weaver asked with a wave of her hand, that familiar buzz leaving as Scarlet's knees hit the floor.

Gasping for air a ripping cough reverberated deep from her chest as she clasped at her throat "I didn't do shit and what's the point in me if I can't even use my power to protect the people close to me???"

"How will you ever learn anything if you only rely on brute force? And I thought you understood why it's so important to keep what you are a secret, if they knew exactly what sort of creature you were they'd want to drive you away and then what would you do?" the witch explained while turning towards the Black Garnet with her hands behind her back in a disappointed tone.

Scarlet spat on the floor before rising to one knee "now why don't I believe you? There are lizard people, blue furry pupilless people, fucking people who look like frogs, flat nosed bears and different

colored ogres, do I need to go on? Everyone's a dick to everyone anyway and at worst they'd think I'm one of your test subjects" Weaver's mask cocked towards her slightly, those whites narrowed.

Hah , she was surprised she knew about those "you shouldn't question me or people's propensity towards acting on their fears, as I remember you should be quite familiar with what happened to your mother and father? Elizabeth was her name..... Such a waste, a mind so old would have been so full of knowledge"

"Don't! Say her name..... All someone like you would've done was use me against her! Don't think I don't know what you did to her corps, using her for your sick fucking experiments" Scarlet growled out, standing up as that familiar darkness flowed like a freezing fire through her veins.

She'd walked into this very room, called by her so-called adoptive mother after misbehaving when about twelve, only to walk in on her basically dissecting her mother with magic in midair "you did that on purpose....."

Shadow Weaver sighed almost sorrowfully, the bottoms of her robe swaying to the left as she turned "you simply didn't understand how important your job would be, and I sent you out the moment I saw you, I thought I had time to finish up before you arrived" she drawled like it wasn't her fault she couldn't close her eyes for months after that without seeing that horrible display of entrails and body parts floating in the air.

"Scarlet, I had to study her, or her death would go to waist, not to mention your abysmal track record with spells, I was trying to figure out why it seemed you've been having so much, trouble" she explained, coughing into her fist as if something had been funny while hovering over to her blank stare at the floor.

"So, tell me why you thought it was a good idea to use that form? And why should I tolerate your total disrespect towards me, not to even mention how much of a disappointment you have been, all I've gained by graciously saving you is a rebellious monster disguised as an Etherian who preys on my prized pupil. Considering how you look you probably fed on not only your attackers but Adora too, are you so weak you can't even spare her from your disgusting animalistic behavior?"

T-this is my fault? You dissected my mother in front of me because I wasn't enough? You don't teach me anything new, you starve me, you punish me when I do what you want, you don't believe me when I tell you the truth, you throw me into solitary for the stupidest things and you think the life you've given me is a fucking blessing?!!?? You degrade me, you treat me as some sort of parasite, you want me to be some powerhouse while at the same time stripping me of any way to actually get stronger, and then you call me useless and weak when I could still stomp everyone around me into the fucking ground!!!!! ***YOUR FUCKING TRASH THAT NOT EVEN RODENTS WOULD EAT!!!***

"Then maybe we should put that to the test" Scarlet snarled.

"What did yo-" entire body bulging Scarlet's arm swiped, black inky energy surrounding her fingertips as they nicked the

underside of Shadow Weavers mask revealing a wide cut up sickly gray eye with a distorted pupil.

Staring into it fully transformed Scarlet sent her careening back with one quick kick in between Weaver's hip and ribs. In one motion the vampire stepped forward, knees bending before flying forward, right fist cocked back while the left hand aimed forward, palm open ready to clear the way or be sacrificed for one decisive hit right through that flimsy wooden mask.

But millimeters away a familiar buzz echoed throughout the room, her knuckles being caressed by a couple gray spindly fingertips "you're lucky Adora needs you for that match or you'd already be **regretting your decisions** " her voice echoed and distorted as rivers of black and red flowed through the witches body "you will report back after that test, here's a preliminary of what exactly you'll be enduring" Weaver's other arm shot forward, stopping by Scarlet's chest as she could only watch in horror while those red sparks gathered before shooting straight through her entire body like a lance.

Weaver was suddenly meters away as her back hammered into the wall before dropping her onto the cold steel floor. Not that she could feel its temperature right now as every nerve in her body convulsed, drool and bile flowing over her chin freely, Scarlet not knowing if she'd ever stop vomiting as her stomach lurched again, and again while she just pressed her forehead into the ground gasping for air. But her lungs only constricted sharply. She could still feel where she'd been hit, the entire way through that lightning had gone feeling like she'd been stabbed by a melting sword.

"Do not question me again and enjoy the little freedom you have left for now" Weaver said coldly before sending her flying out the door, back slamming into another wall knocking the little air she'd managed to breathe, out of her lungs.

The next ten minutes were a struggle of feeling returning to muscles that repeatedly kept constricting again and again while trying to catch her breath. Shaky legs pushed her to lean up against the wall, eyes scrunched shut as she just stood there waiting to be able to start her journey back to class....

"Haaaah..... Haaaahhh..... Ngh....." she wheezed, trudging forward, one hand on the wall and the other wrapped around her torso.

Where is all the fairness in this world??? Scarlet questioned, *what's the point in trying.....* . She asked, but the answer was obvious as she limped towards class with a fiery glare in her eye. *I could barely touch her.... Those fucking liars.....*

25 minutes later, south wing, classroom 6A

"We should've waited" Adora verbalized, fingernail in-between her teeth as one knee bounced like someone had installed an engine inside of it.

"She would've known, you know it, I know it, Scar knows it....." Catra murmured into her forearm, half laying on the table at the

back, other arm hooked around her head.

"I should go back, maybe I can still talk to-"

"Nope, not happening, you, pulled me out remember? And Weavers got a stick up her ass, again.... Why did I say that out loud?" the feline groaned out that last part, seemingly trying to bury her face into the table with a disgusted gag.

That did not help Adora's nerves whatsoever as the text and pictures on the holo board blurred. Nail snapping from in-between her front teeth, Adora's fingers trailed back and forth through the hair on the sides of her head. What did she do wrong? Wasn't she quick enough during the test? *I should've noticed it was too much for her, shit..... Everything was fine, I knew, I-I knew Weaver might ask but it shouldn't have mattered... We got full marks and that was just another fight, did I miss something? Last test was one hundred out of one hundred, there was that janky simulation with those bots, but we were still the fastest out of everyone.*

So why was she held back? I had everything under control. It wasn't enough, Weaver had to take over because I couldn't handle them. But they did amazing, I made sure of it, I knew they could handle it, no one really got hurt that won't quickly heal. But they lied; I should've just broken his arm; this is all my fault, I-I failed them. They don't fear you enough Weaver's voice echoed, *you have to make them respect you through fear or they'll think they can do whatever they want-*

“Hey! Adora! Stop!” Catra’s voice pierced through from so far away as claws prickled her shoulder.

“S-stop what?”

“You're about to rip your hair out, seriously you're freaking me out, what’s going on in that head of yours? It’s not like this is anything new” Adora was lucky Catra always wanted to sit at the back, because now no one could see her posture break or the way her breath quickened to the pace of her ever-increasing heartbeat.

“I know, and I’m sorry...” Catra just blinked as Adora refocused on the holo board where a guy covered in red chitin exited one of their simulated forts.

Two cadets flanked him, one carrying a case with a red light in the middle while the other pushed forward a light blue lizard woman. They all had sensory plates on, some even had full helmets while others opted for a simple visor. It was required in sim training to gauge damage taken among other things but, what currently perplexed Adora was how he’d gotten so far into his opponent's territory while the main battle still raged on in the middle. Even so not long after the teacher paused the recording, asking about how they performed in their minds and what they could improve.

Keeping her mind occupied was the only thing stopping the creeping sense of helplessness. She simply had to do better, or everything would collapse into a million pieces...

“Wait what are you sorry abou-” the feline was cut off by the classroom door sliding open.

“Miss, you are late by over half an hour-”

“I know, Weaver kept me-”

“This better not be an excuse, if I find out you real-”

“Then what? You’ll give me detention? Maybe give me more work and make me do planks until my arms can’t hold up anymore? Just keep explaining tactics and hypothetical engagements instead of butting into business with people above your station since that’s apparently all your good for. Now what the hell are all of you looking at? Eyes front” Scarlet spat out with a glare, looking down on everyone around while clutching her side tightly.

Her haggard appearance might’ve conveyed weakness but the way an icy cold spread through the classroom, permeating from the royally pissed off looking girl, also showed the extraordinarily short fuse she was on. Lonnie might’ve sighed in front of them with even Kyle not paying much mind, but the rest didn’t know if this bark had any bite behind it. Even so every cadet knew not to try their luck with the Hordes magic users, all being very standoffish not to mention aggressive and proud, even more so than the normal cadets in special squadrons being raised for potential leadership positions.

So, like now everyone avoided or straight up ignored the blatant disrespect towards a higher up, since it was highly speculated most of the magic users were hopped up on some enhancer making them this way. Though Adora knew like Catra who scooted one seat over before gesturing for Scarlet to sit, that she wouldn't act on anything, she was just blowing off steam.

"Are you ok? Weaver didn't write you up did she?" Adora asked, lightly squeezing Scarlet's shoulder as she pulled the chair back before plopping down with a muffled groan and clenched teeth.

"What? Yeah, just peachy, she just didn't appreciate the way I conveyed my grievances with our situation. Oh, and as punishment she's going to bury me in books to try and better learn magic, so you won't see me for a few days" frowning Adora pursed her lips in frustration.

"Then why do you have to antagonize her; Weaver just wants you to be more respectful, like now you didn't need to be like that with our teacher, we're about to turn sixteen and become senior cadets, we're basically adults we need to start acting like it"

"Don't start that crap with me now..... I'm not in the mood" Scarlet shrugged her arm off with a sideways glance and mouth in a line.

It stung, the cold shoulder as her fingers tentatively stuttered away. Catra's blue and yellow eyes darted between them as she lay there, both arms crossed on the table with two clawed fingers rising like a flick before hiding away. A message conveyed, *lay off*

, but with this look it was more of a, *don't, just let her cool off* . Adora's face fell, and she resisted the urge to.... Do anything at all as Scarlet's chest rose and fell, lungs squeaking with every breath....

3 years before Thaymor, Catra's memories

Catra couldn't remember the number of times she'd become second fiddle, or the amount of times Shadow Weaver had brushed off her accomplishments if not simply say it was thanks to Adora she'd ever made it this far. She also couldn't remember... How many times she'd been frozen in place, losing all control of what would happen, terrified as her field of view narrowed to the shadows surrounding her with a dark red ghostly person looming over her. Her head just seemed so fuzzy when she tried to remember until parts would come back in violent flashes...

But Catra's body remembered, it remembered it all vividly. The way she shrunk in on herself, eyes falling to the floor dreading the moment her head would snap up as a deep hoarse voice yelled at her to **LOOK AT ME** . Forcing her to watch and stare while waiting for her inevitable punishment, heart sinking while she trembled, holding her breath in hope she wouldn't bother with her.... It's why she intimately recognized when her stepmother had been involved with someone, the way they tried to seem smaller as a hollow glazed over look reflected from their eyes.

It's why I know you're lying your ass off, lessons? When you look like that.... Something happened, but even if you won't tell... I still know..... .

Most days when the heaviness would get too much because of a list of reason like some other kids said something shitty about her, taunting her or when Weaver'd just decided to shit on her day for whatever reason after weeks of being called a disappointment or rat or such... Maybe throw it all in the mix while others were just extra annoying and Adora's presence couldn't keep her standing anymore, Catra would hide away.

Maybe on the roof, their abandoned supply closet or just some small dark space where she could curl up into a ball so no one could find her. Adora still always found her after a while somehow... Blue eyes lighting up as she climbed to places the blond had no business getting too. Simply asking what she was doing there? That she'd missed class, before with a gentle look asking without words if she was ok....

Catra never answered honestly, simply brushing her off or just saying she was just tired, the blond almost never pushing but still being attentive... It made her claw at her own arms and legs as she resisted the pathetic urge to cling onto her and just... Let go... She didn't quite know what all that would in tale but the images popping in her head were both laughably weak and confusing.... But it always made her heart ache for something.... Constrict so painfully. Yet relief would partially wash over her while letting her imagination run wild...

Maybe that was why she'd broken down in front of Scarlet too, because she was such a fucking animal that just had no self-control while biting down on her lip as hard as she could, blood flowing. But the tears still escaped, one, two, maybe even five. Even so it was enough for Catra to see the pity in her eyes like she was some small child that needed to be comforted. She scoffed at the notion but then, then the red eyed girl had done

something weird, lifting some of her shirt revealing fading spider webbing like scars.

“She hurts me too; I know how you feel” Scarlet had said with a forced smile while the abandoned supply closets door clanged shut.

Catra’d crawled forward on all fours after shouting at her, screaming at her teary eyed to stop staring like she was helpless, like everyone else saying she was a useless parasite..... Scarlet yelped as her claws traced the scars that’d soon disappear like it’d never happened. She’d pulled away only for the red eyed girl to take her hand and put it back.

“You still have us.... You don’t need to be alone...”

Catra’s eyes darted up to meet a genuine smile “why does she only do it to us?”

Scarlet shrugged “I don’t know..... But it doesn't matter because one day she can’t touch any of us anymore, because we’ll be stronger than her” she’d kneeled wiping the few tears that’d escaped away with her thumb “do you really think your weak because she said so?”

2 years and 1 month before Thaymor, the present, west wing, holo arena projection room quadrant

A meter or two behind the Blond, Catra kept her eyes on Scarlet's back and the way her shoulder blades kept bulging out while her arms stretched. Having recovered quickly compared to anyone else she was now almost posturing as she exhaled slowly, half lidded eyes staring forward.

Catra flexed her claws uneasily while chewing on her cheek "well she looks pumped; did something happen between... You know yesterday?" Lonnie suddenly asked, elbowing her arm.

Catra grumbled out a sigh, side eyeing the other brunet "not that it's any of your business, they went and cried to their platoon leader and we're kinda fighting em now"

"Ohhh, that still doesn't explain-"

"You can't be this slow, Weav- agh..... Fucking, whatever, I need you to go ahead with Adora and the others on the next turn" Lonnie blinked wide eyed, putting a finger up in question with Kyle and Rogelio also staring at her.

"D-did, did you hit your head? You actually want to give up time with Adora to me?"

"Why do you say it so weirdly?? No just do what I say without whining for once, pleaseeee" Catra drawled, sarcasm dripping off

that last word.

“Ahh... I see, sure I’ll distract Adora for you, won’t even spoil you two's victory surprise for her since you so kindly shared yesterday” the braided girl winked with a grin to Catra’s horror before jogging ahead just as the turn was coming.

“What fucking surprise?!?!?!? The hell was she talking about....” she squinted at her back trying to process what that shit stain had just said.

Said shit stain shoulder bumped the blond to Catra’s immediate discomfort, but her sights quickly changed as Rogelio and Kyle followed Lonnie’s lead by slotting themselves in front of the vampire. Frowning Scarlet stumbled, almost stepping on the blond boy's foot who smiled back at her apologetically.

Narrowing her eyes and very slightly cocking her head so some bangs fell over her face. She seemed mildly annoyed but that coupled with her already clearly hostile demeanor made Kyle almost falter when Catra hooked an arm around the vampire's chest.

“W-wha?” yanking her down the other corridor blond hair swayed only a meter away “where are the-”

“Don’t worry about it, they’ll be back by your side before you know it, in the meanwhile, what's your plan fo-” Lonnie trailed off

as the other cadets in their group funneled forward leaving no opening to turn back.

Ugh Grunting Scarlet's back hit the wall as Catra planted one clawed finger on her chest "w-what is it now?!"

"You lied, what happened with Weaver?" she asked, narrowing her eyes at those slightly extended fangs. Adora had probably noticed it too, which was why she'd been keeping such a close eye on her after class.

"About what? And you know what happened, she got all pissy about respect and not doing a good enough job protecting Adora, now let's go we're-" fangs growing she was gritting her teeth, probably trying to keep from changing while brushing past with her hand on the felines shoulder.

"Then lift your shirt" Catra rebutted, grabbing Scarlet's wrist.

Her entire expression twitched, and eyes widened for a fraction of a moment before hardening "your being ridiculous, I already told you everything and I'm sorry I can't apparently be in a shit mood without-"

"Look, Adora didn't say anything because she doesn't want to hurt your pride, but we both know you going off halfcocked like this will get you in more trouble than the amount of damage you can do to whoever you're mad at. You shouldn't be alone like this"

Catra said crossing her arms while her eyes demurely darted to the side with a quick huff. At this point the feline regretted not bringing Adora with her, she hated to admit this, but the blond was something of a haven for the both of them.

Being with her was usually calming on even the worst of days... Though this wasn't something she could completely understand. The pain..... Agony of being on the receiving end of Weavers wrath.

"Like you almost ever listen to that yourself? And are you sure about that?" Scarlet scoffed lips moving into a smirk.

Eyes rolling Catra frowned "I didn't mean literally; I'm just trying to make sure you don't fly off the fucking handle, now what did Weaver say, solitary? No blood for another week?"

The vampires' brows knitted together as she intently stared into Catra's eyes before letting out a frustrated groan "fine! Here are you happy?" Catra's eyes went wide as angry
crimson uneven lines shot out of one big red mark in the middle of Scarlet's chest. That would've killed or at least done permanent damage to almost any other person she thought, fingers hovering over the red skin shooting down over her ribs and up over her collar bone Scarlet suddenly pulled her shirt down.

"T-that's a lot of..... She usually isn't this.... I mean she's normally more subtle or at least less-"

“Blunt? I know but I, I-I just got so fucking angry.....”

“What did you do?” Catra asked, grabbing her shoulders trying to get her to look at her but....

“I lost control, and still, I could barely do anything to her.....” she said shakily, letting go of her fist as her head fell to the side eyes glazing over....

“How long?”

“I have the match and then..... Well, you know, so I don’t think I can get in more trouble if that’s what you're wondering”

“Adora will ask” Catra said in a monotone voice.

“Don’t tell her, just say I went to some magic training camp or something, I won’t be gone for more than a week I don’t think, I don’t want her to think this is her fault.....”

“Fine but doing something stupid now will only make it worse” teeth grinding against each other above Catra, the feline knew.

“This, this is also the only time I’ll get to do something, you’d do the same” Scarlet’s muscles were tense, hard as steel while

trembling with impotent rage. Catra knew the feeling all too well, not being able to do anything about the unfairness and wanting to break something, anything at all just so you felt a modicum of control again.

"And I'm telling you that now's not the time, think, we can get back at them later, even Adora will help as long as it doesn't make things worse!"

"Things literally can't get worse! Now I don't need your help, so just stay out of my way and Weaver won't pay attention to you. You should be happy" being shoved to the side Catra just stood there, hands balling into fists as Scarlet almost spat that last part out.

"Why would I be happy....." she growled deep from her chest and just out under her breath, but Scarlet kept walking either ignoring or not hearing what she'd basically whispered.....

6 minutes later, the arena, red base

Hands on the metallic guard of a holo table dimly lighting up the blond, Adora moved two projections of bots back and on top of their base. They could provide covering fire since she couldn't get turret placements up there, Catra would also insist on using them as a trap or reinforcement. That was the thing with Catra, her tactics were deceptive and almost always evasive, baiting your enemy into a death of a thousand cuts. Certainly not the regular Horde procedure of brute force, hitting fast and hard overwhelming your enemy with sheer numbers and power.

“You said they’d be here soon”

“Ugh.... You know Catra, she’s always a little late at least....” Lonnie shifted in place with a sideways glance towards the door.

Sighing and brows knitting together Adora rubbed her eyes with one hand “fine, we’ll just have to start without them, the match is about to start” she said eyes darting to the digital clock on the wall, big red numbers ticking down, zero five and forty-three seconds.

Sharply Inhaling through her nose Adora quickly surveyed the room as all twenty-three cadets watched her with expectation in their eyes. All these people were relying on her to get them through this, to win and keep them number one on the leaderboard so not one of them had to be punished, get extra work or have their ration pass reduced if not revoked for any amount of time.

“Everyone knows their positions; we’ve trained in sims hundreds of times and won every group battle up till now and we won’t start losing now. You know the drill, group d and e man the walls, group f stays in the interior for further instructions while b and c go on the offensive. The bots will give support but don’t rely on them too much, they’re expendable and highly predictable. Remember there are two ways we lose, if they bring back this” Adora explained before stepping back and slapping a long rectangular box glowing red in the middle “or we all get knocked out and then my personal loss, if they take me out, that one you won’t have to care about since I’d like to see them try getting

those bonus points” some chuckles echoed around her, the moral of her comrades being high, yet there was a heaviness in Adora’s gut as she glanced at the closed door by the side of the room. They still weren't here and after Weaver.... And then the way she was in class... *Guys I need you right now..* ..

“Now get to your positions and wait for orders” Adora ordered, fingers snapping at Lonnie.

“Yeah?”

“You're on point outside, don’t take them head on but spread out and fall back until you get back to turret range and take my helmet”

“W-wait? You're not coming?” the brunet asked, staring at the training helmet with a big white number on it.

Adora shook her head “I changed the plan, there's something going on right now and I can’t-”

Door hydraulics churned as two sets of footsteps suddenly approached “where have you two-” Adora started but eyes darting down she caught her tongue.

Catra’s expression was stressful, and she was making hand signs by her side away from any unwanted gazes. RED, red, red not

good, angry very bad. She emphasized, pupils flying from her to Scarlet rapidly. Softly hitting Lonnie's arm, Adora mouthed *go* while pointing before putting a hand on Scarlet's shoulder.

"You ok Scar?"

"Sure am, now let's go get this over with" she answered patting Adora's shoulder with a calm smile before taking a step towards the door downstairs.

"I changed our plans; Lonnie will draw them here before attacking with reinforcements"

"Wait, I thought we'd attack? No Adora we need to be out there, these idiots will undoubtedly fuck it up"

"Well tough luck, we're staying back until I say otherwise"

"No, you're staying back, you'll be safe here while I make sure not one of them gets to you..... Yes..."

Scarlet sounded like she was half convincing herself there while staring out of the turret window with an almost hungry grin-

"Scar your fangs are showing!"

“Oh, they are? Well shit how did that happen?” she asked patting her teeth with slender fingers barely touching the tip.

“Scarlet this isn’t funny, Adora is right let's stay back for now, I bet they're stupid enough to come into turret range, we might not even need to attack their base” Adora’s gaze snapped to Catra, she wasn’t one to care if other cadets got hurt while she went on her own, hell she liked to gloat over their humiliation especially after outsmarting people in a fight.

No Catra was all about efficiency and taking advantage of others weaknesses while making fun of them. It was oddly endearing though not something Adora condoned “you can stay in here with her if you want, but I’m not wasting my time, I’ll show her..... And them why they should’ve just had the decency to stay silent” there was five seconds left on the timer and in those five seconds she was gone, flying out the window with inky blackness covering the whites of her eyes as those ruby-like irises glowed a searing red in this shallowly lit room.

“Scar- SHIT, go!”

“What about your plan?!”

“You don’t think I planned around you??? Go, make sure she doesn't do anything stupid, please”

Catra shakily kept Adora's gaze, mouth working to say something before just nodding with a hardened expression. Focus switching back to the holo table as the feline slipped through the same window, Adora sighed in indignation. Not only did she have to change the plan last minute, but Scarlet wasn't listening to her anymore because of whatever had happened earlier and all she could do was control the bots for now, until....

"Lonnie, can you hear me?"

"Yes sir"

"I'm sending more troops, your still my troops commander there but cover Scarlet when she gets there"

"O-ok? Have plans changed again?"

"Yes"

Outside, moments later

Sliding over the steel floor, green plasma skidded inches over Lonnie's helmet while a couple bounced off her arm shield before her boots hit a jagged boulder. The moment they'd engaged in this hard light holographic forest Lonnie found herself under fire, even now at least ten soldiers and five bots rushed over the ankle-deep projected river.

Fully armored she peaked, rifle falling on the side of the slightly glowing light green rock surface only to flinch back as sparks splashed over her “fuck!” she yelled blind firing back “their rushing us! Formation C! And get the bots to the front!”

“Roger!” Kyle shouted back, the mouth of a rifle appearing a little over ten meters away behind her.

Two bots fell from the trees on both of her sides, yellow eyes lighting up orange before releasing a barrage of static plasma letting her dislodge from the rock. She had to get out of here even if Adora wanted them to charge suddenly like normal. The moment Catra got back, Adora just lost her focus and now wasn’t here like usual, changing plans multiple times because of something going on between those three.

“We better not lose because of-” the two bots waddling backwards creaked before the machinery screamed, their legs giving out as static sparks bounced on their surface.

Grador, the tall dark-haired guy from Grizzlor’s species roared lifting the bot carcass “Adora!” Lonnie winced on the inside as she got behind a tree, falling on one knee and lighting him up.

Kyle’s and her plasma hammered into the bots metal to no avail as it suddenly hurtled towards them “get down!” she pushed the blond boy aside before diving for the ground as the tree shattered into tens of flickering jagged pieces.

Rolling back screams and shouts echoed around her as more enemy cadets poured over the projected water, rising the hill before falling on their stomachs and providing covering fire or perching behind a tree. Loud error sounds reverberated around her as X's lit up over many of the cadet's chest plates one after another. *Are they all here??? We're being surrounded!*

Another bot fell further by their side crumpling to the ground under a hail of plasma and shutting down as fully armored cadets with shields and stun batons ran towards them "retreat!" she ordered hitting two cadets square in the chest, X's lighting up brightly when another roar reverberated with a hiss following it.

"Where are your friends!?!" Grador growled as a red lizard person almost slithered across the ground only to be tackled into a roll.

Green scales glinted under a couple plasma bolts, those two maws wide open full of razor-sharp teeth or well, the red one was missing some on one side. Rogelio hammered punches into his straddled opponent while Kyle pushed into her side rifle rattling as Lonnie's squad was locked in close combat, staves and batons out forcing them to fight.

Weapons clanging together Lonnie's attention snapped back to the giant man flying towards them, pupilless eyes on her. Arms in front, the plates ate Kyles plasma bolts before he landed in front of them with a massive grin. Kyle flew, back smashing into a bot as more error sounds echoed around her.

Rifle jerking out of her arms she smacked away the hand reaching out for her before jamming a fist in his gut. He lurched over but smiled while grabbing both her wrists before craning back, kicking her in between the ribs. Air jettisoned out her lungs and she almost choked on her own spit, but he wasn't done. Pulling her around before slamming her back down the plate on her still hadn't screamed out an X making her a dead combatant letting him pull back a clenched fist. All Lonnie could do was gasp for air with wide eyes as-

Knees smashed into the side of his head sending him careening towards the ground as a grinning fanged half open mouth giggled "found you!" Scarlet rolled, legs stretching her out to a stop before sending her forward like a spring, palm open as Grador stopped himself from falling with one bulging leg.

"Y-you.... ARGH!" her roared swinging one burly arm, only for it to be stopped cold in its tracks.

Reaching over herself Lonnie trembled while shifting to her side before pushing up with her arms and letting her helmet slide off. Bile splattered the ground as she watched Grador flinch back only to be yanked forward. An inky black void surrounded those glaring red irises and again, he lurched over but this time spit hung from his lips and sharp teeth in a horrified grimace.

Lonnie could count on one hand how many times she'd seen this part of Scarlet. It'd always been in the back of her mind, but she'd almost forgotten as it'd almost always been glimpses of momentary rage but now, now she watched as whatever Scarlet was whaled into someone double her size without even for a moment letting him fight back.

His chest suddenly screamed out a massive red X indicating he was out but with a wide grin she just kept going, ripping it off before jamming two fingers under his ribs and pushing "I know your stupid enough to not have come up with your little plan, where's the scorpion guy???" he just gurgled, face beaten into a bloody mess, cuts and bruises littering every part of it.

"Not talking?" something broke, cracking under the palm on his ribs making him scream "c-shtle! BHASE!" his eyes shot open, pointing behind them with one shaky finger.

"Scarlet... Stop you're gonna get disqualified"

"Psht, yeah right, like Weaver would let Adora's team have anything but a spotless record" she scoffed before glaring down the wheezing teenager "useless trash" the red eyed girl growled with a tsk, spitting before sending him flying down the hill with one swift kick.

Then she ran, plasma rocketing past only for whatever cadet to get in her way to soon be sent hurtling into a rock. Roughly sucking in air Lonnie surveyed around only seeing a silhouette of a person with claws and a tail dashing after Scarlet after dropping a cadet to the ground. Apparently, all those error sounds hadn't just been her own troops getting knocked out, she thought falling onto her back again and coughing out a sigh of relief.

A snout suddenly sniffed the side of her head as a familiar chuckle sang beside her “looks like we’re still in it” the dirty blond lanky boy said.

“Hehe.... No shit Kyle-” she laughed before launching into a coughing fit “god he hits hard...”

“You ok?” she just nodded, taking his arm before limping back as Rogelio let out a long grunt “yeah? Well, I think he deserved the beating” she answered while he huffed out a growl.

“I just hope she doesn't get into trouble, she’s nice when she isn’t mad”

“I’m not sure that’s possible anymore, remember what they talked about in class?” Rogelio and Kyle’s faces fell.

“Yeah...”

Further ahead, nearby green base

Legs pumping, Scarlet felt no strain, no usual heaviness that came with constant battle as she almost floated past jagged trees with flickering leaves hand stretching out and fingers clasping forward. The few cadets covering for their comrades moved so slowly, so easy to hunt, so easy to track down as colored fog trailed around in this dark void of a world. For Hordak’s sake things were so

much easier this way. One strike was enough to knock one’s head into a tree before kicking off the trunk and jumping over plasma bolts skidding under her folded knees.

Errrrrr! blared from the cadet's chest plate as he slammed to the ground the wind having been knocked out of his lungs. As fun as this was actually using her full strength unrestrained by simply not caring. Weaver was already going to do her worst even though she did nothing wrong, so what was the point? She could run and laugh in between these projected trees smelling for prey, seeing only black and gray silhouettes with rivers of light in them.

A clearing came with walls and moving round things on the top with long cylindrical things beside them. Only two cadets could be seen hiding behind those turrets as the bots hopped down their eyes turning white in her vision. They were undoubtedly actually orange now, charging their eye beams. But Scarlet never stopped running as warmth surged through her veins, inky black energy wrapping around her hands.

They fired as she did, sending bolts of pure magic to smash with the plasma in a static boom while the turrets were barely missing her. Green plasma splashing the projected dirt blackening the steel only a centimeter underneath she could almost smell the panic as their heartrates increased. Or maybe that was smoke, she wasn’t sure, but soon they’d be afraid, especially the person hiding in their fort...

Jamming a fist through the reinforced glass, Scarlet ripped cords and circuit boards out of the bot's eye before lifting it as bolts rattled its plated armor. About to throw it something slender

slinked past the corner of her eye, a shadow dashing up the wall as the other bot nearby was grounded with gashes littering its sparking innards and plates.

Chucking the bot, she was holding onto, her knees then bent before rocketing off the ground as the turrets nose jerked upward. Plasma shot off into the air harmlessly letting Scarlet land on the forts fortified wall. The seemingly three fingered cadet's visor snapped at her as she grabbed his throat after dropping down.

The dark silhouette of the second turret swiveled towards them and the corner of Scarlet's mouth quirked up "w-wai-" was all the cadet managed to croak out before being used as a shield from the turrets barrage. He grunted and groaned as the vampire pushed forward, the thuds from static plasma not stopping her for a moment until it suddenly just, stopped.

Peaking behind the twitching cadet, the turret was already pointing down, and a red X glowed on the other cadet's chest accompanied by a bandaged up clawed foot. Eyes fleeting up a tail swayed to the side as heterochromic eyes stared down at her while the feline crossed her arms.

"Are you done?"

"Ehhh.... I have one more stop"

Catra narrowed her eyes before sighing and grinding her teeth together, head snapping towards the fort “let's get this over with.... I’m getting sick of running after you” she drawled head falling towards her.

Scarlet chuckled looking at the slightly angulating bands of magic disappear and reappear inside of different parts of Catra periodically. It made her scratch her head sometimes why she was the only one this happened with “now you know how I feel” she dropped down and sauntered over to the door before kicking it down with a grunt and heavy creaking bang!

“Pfft...” Catra huffed jogging across the wall beside her before hopping onto a windowsill upstairs, claws nicking the edges before slipping inside.

Leaping up the spiraling stairs before busting through the upstairs side door launching herself at another lizard, its eyes widening before its head clonked on the holo table with a meaty whack. Two others turned towards her only for one of them to fall on their back while static shocked the woman's chest plate.

Catra looked up to the vampire while pointing her shock baton towards the last cadet in the room who quickly ate a black bolt, his chest plate blaring “where is he???”

“Who?” Catra asked, dislodging the enemy's case with a green glow in the middle.

“The scorpion man! This squad's cadet captain.... Grador lied to me” Scarlet murmured while staring at the blips on the holo table.

“The meat head? Sheesh didn’t think he was smart enough-”

CRASH!

Catra flinched in the corner of Scarlet’s eye as she hammered her fist through the projector, the map flickering as a force captain icon entered the fort on the other side of the battlefield “FUCK” Scarlet growled before launching out of the window.

“WAIT! Where are you going???”

Rolling she sprinted through the gate; her revenge was so close but now he was suddenly on the other side of the map???? *I don’t have time for this....* ..

Back at red base

Adora’s foot tapped as she watched the yellow blips regroup before pushing forward. They’d won the first engagement, yet Adora found herself gnawing on her thumbs nail. Their numbers had diminished considerably more than in any other battle though at least two people had reached the enemy fort... Not that she

could contact them Adora thought as her eyes darted to the second blip suddenly rocketing towards her?

She sighed in relief yet as she opened her eyes again, she found herself numbly staring at the dot. Adora wasn't stupid nor had any head injury made her lose brain cells like Catra liked to joke. She knew something more had happened for Scarlet to act like this, it was obvious. But she couldn't do anything about it, she couldn't fix their problems when Catra or Scarlet decided to be like this. It made her have to do everything the hard way, leaving Lonnie to lead the charge when she should be the one there making sure everything went fine and now, they'd lost over half her troops and bots.... Just so she cou-

Something clanged further by her side, and she pulled out her side arm while unclasping a staff hilt before un collapsing it on both sides "whose there?" she asked while backtracking but quickly swiping the holo table controls with two fingers as multiple forms rushed out the left side door.

"Surrender golden child" a brown-haired tall man with red carapace and two giant claws for hands said.

The blond backed away as two rifles pointed at her while two armored cadets wielding batons slowly inched towards her. Adora chuckled before standing up straight with her weapons by her sides to the scorpion man's frown "what's so fun-"

Two lights blinked alive in two corners of the room's roof, one bot falling on top of one cadet aiming their rifle at Adora while the

other dropped onto another with a baton. The blond ducked shooting the closer now laying down cadet and eliciting a loud *errrrrr* out of his chest plate as the bots crossfired the two other cadets left standing.

Adora heard a frustrated growl before metal tore somewhere near the door they'd come through. Quickly sniping the other cadet further away under the other bot, Adora jumped out from behind the holo table lighting up the scorpion man.

He rapidly snipped off two of the bot's legs beside him before jamming a claw in its eye and charging with its broken carcass in front "shoot him!" the blond ordered as the second bot stepped forward, an orange ray beamed barely doing any damage to the metal but sending sparks littering across it.

GRHHHGHGGH he groaned while smashing into the second bot before ripping the first one apart with his claws and cutting the second one into pieces with a few snaps of his pincers. Plasma splashed off his red carapace back, these things being set to too low of a power setting to break anything. Some species just had such an unfair advantage though Adora wouldn't trade her hands for that.....

For his size he was surprisingly quick, the tip of a claw knocking the almost useless pistol out of her hand. If she didn't hit any of the fleshy parts, there wasn't much it could do. But staff in hand she parried a forward strike knocking it aside before striking his chin and spinning around lodging the tip in his gut.

Only to hear a klink as he was barely knocked back with a sudden gust of air leaving his mouth "I don't know how you knew my plan or that I'd want to capture you but you're gonna have to hit harder than that!" pulling back, her staff snapped in two forcing the blond to roll backwards over the holo table as a claw fell smashing through the projector.

Wielding the now half-staff like a sword she swiped at his legs, him jumping just over it as the holo tables glass crackled under his feet on landing. A stinger barely glanced off her pulled back weapon only for her to be pushed back by a flurry of blows. Ducking pincers, letting them bounce off her forearm and biceps, Adora's footwork kept her in this, even with his strength advantage.

He chased Adora around the holo table, the blond trying to find an opening-

"ARHH!" she screamed against gritted teeth as she blocked a wide swing, something snapping in her forearm making the piece of staff clatter to the floor. Left hand now hanging by her side she was lifted in the air while clasping at the claw holding her under her shoulder.

"Got-" he barely got out, stinger rising just as Adora's forehead slammed into his nose, sending him careening back while her feet hit the floor again.

Snatching up her staff she swept his legs, sending him crashing to the floor. Adora saw his eyes widen in shock as she descended,

staff pointing down in a high stabbing motion.

Errrrrr!

The Red team wins by elimination! blared over the intercoms, the trees and rocks outside disappearing, everyone return to the lounge to receive evaluations.

"Where is she?" Shadow Weaver loomed over Adora as a soldier with white stripes on his armor readjusted her bone in one quick motion.

"I-I don't know...." the blond answered, flinching as she sat there, arm extended for the medic to attach a splint.

"You need not lie to me Adora, I've taken precious time from my schedule to teach her a very special lesson and I do not have tim-"

"I'm not lying! I saw her at the start and then she just bolted for the enemy and, do you have to take her today?"

"I do, it is very important she learns.... Where is Catra? Surely you three would be together celebrating even after such a mediocre victory" Adora's gaze fell to the floor, that was obvious, over half her troops were hypothetically killed and she barely.....

“I understand that sometimes things might be difficult, and I’ll admit your troops, especially those two seemed to have gone off on their own. But Adora” Weaver cooed, caressing her cheek with boney gray fingers “this is why you must control them more closely, have a tighter leash so to say, I know you know they need direction, a firm hand to keep them in check”

“I-I know..... They’ve been doing really well it's just; it was unfair for the other cadets to lie like that.... And then, I don’t understand why you held her back.....”

Weaver tutted at that while kneeling down almost to eye level but looming just above her face “Adora, you know I have too thoroughly make sure what happened, it was nothing more, you know I only say and do these things because I believe in your potential, even so it seems you still lack too much experience.... You’ve disappointed me today, what would’ve happened if you lost control over your troops like this against actual princesses?” Shadow Weaver asked with a sigh and mask tilting to the side.

Adora swallowed not reacting to the stim being injected to her arm as she stared into her palm “they’d have died.....”

“Unfortunately, yes, this is why I must be so hard on you, or none of you will survive out there and I do not wish for that nor should you”

“I don’t! I-I don’t.....”

“I know, go rest, I’ll find her”

“W-wait, can you let her come back early? It's our induction day or, birth... Day in a couple of days.... And we got a little free time since we... Won” Adora asked shakily, the act feeling dirty even though they’d gained a few legitimate rest days for winning....

She could feel Shadow Weavers apprizing gaze on the back of her lowered head, completely prepared for a straight up no and a scolding telling her she shouldn’t get so comfortable-

“I’ll see what I can do, now rest” Adora snapped up, eyes wide and blinking as Weaver floated away down the hall.

“Thank you!” she bowed to Weavers dismissive wave.

10 minutes later

Stalking through the corridors Scarlet peeked just behind a corner looking both ways tentatively. No one was there, no shadows moving, or flickering lights so she crept forward to see some cadets with X covered plates turning another corner where hydraulics churned with a hiss.

“Haaa.....” she exhaled open mouthed almost like a low hiss as four teeth burned in her gums while licking her lips.

They all limped forward, scuffed and bruised, blood lightly staining the floor. There was still an unquenchable rage numbing Scarlet, consuming her mind as it felt like a void was swirling in her chest, heavy and cold. Dashing around the second corner she’d arrived. The green sign above said room C3 showers instead of their A1. Heart hammered against her ribs and hand hovered over the console. Her vision changed; tens of silhouettes filled with rivers of light came into view. Their forms blurry, some deeper inside, their features gone but those big claws were undeniably his. Scarlet’s palm pressed into the console making the door slide up as she stepped forward, saliva gathering in her mouth.

“You couldn’t just take your loss in stride” she murmured, heads snapping towards her.

“We already lost, what do you want?” he asked, sounding muffled to her as a fog settled over her brain, eyes fixated on their beating glowing hearts.

“You?” she answered, pupils forming into slits while her fist crashed into the console by her side. The lights winked out as she wetted her fang with her tongue, grin wide and maliciously gleeful.

“To run like the prey, you are”

20 minutes later

Tongue hung outside her mouth Scarlet panted, fingers wedged in-between the door her arms strained against the shirt's wet splotchy fabric. The metal creaked and bent before snapping out the side, whole thing now pushed like a normal door. Scarlet squeezed through, head clearing as the inky darkness retreated behind her eyelids like water.

Hands soaked in crimson, she stared at the vibrant color. Her mind was clear, whatever void which had grown in her chest now silenced and replaced by intense heat. Yet as the last drop of black ink left the whites of her eyes it turned cold as if someone had gripped her heart. Chest tight she fell, breath caught just in her throat. Why'd she done that? The fury she'd felt, it'd eaten her alive and still half of her was overjoyed, proud.

Bile rose and a hand shot up to her drenched lips. *I lost control* , she finally concluded-

"Scar? SCAR, what happened?!?"

"No! Stay back" she flailed, arms in front and eyes scrunching shut as the feline kneeled "don't look at me...." she whimpered.

"Why? Can you tell me?" she asked, and Scarlet pointed to the half ripped open door.

There was no use hiding it, a quick glance showed Catra's nose scrunching as her eyes darted around the darkness "are you hurt?" Scarlet shook her head, arms falling as a single tear rolled down her cheek.

"Ok" soft hands pulled her close, face nuzzled into a warm chest as Catra hugged her head.

"Please don't tell Adora..... Please....."

"I won't" Catra whispered into Scarlet's scalp while she trembled in her embrace, the only thing feeling even remotely real right now.....

"I didn't mean too, I wasn't in-"

" **What** did you **do?!** " a multilayered voice yelled as a chill swept past and light was swallowed by shadows.

Small trembles ran through the arms and body holding her while the hairs on Catra's skin stood "I still hear breathing inside, they're still alive" Catra said shakily while tightening around her.

"Do you know how many problems this causes?? I should just put a shock collar on a beast like you" Shadow Weaver growled, dark

tendrils surrounding the half-broken door.

It slammed to the opposite wall before single red eyed creatures shrieked through the air into the doorway “this is why I tell you not to use that part of you, you are and always have been a predator, a monster always on the brink, hungry and destructive. You will learn to control and suppress your baser instincts before you hurt Adora, or I will chain you to the wall until you do, now come. With. Me”

Shakily a yowl rumbled in the feline's chest “don’t” Scarlet croaked out, standing up on unsteady legs.

“Catra didn’t do anything.....”

“No, not this time, now follow me, not only did you leave Adora with a broken arm now you’ve done this, not to even mention your earlier actions”

“I know.....” Scarlet’s eyes stuck to the floor, crimson dripping from her fingertips.

“Do you really need to do this??!? This isn’t just her fault! It’s yours to-”

“You dar-”

“It’s ok, just, share my ration bar on induction day while I’m away, ok?” Catra’s hands balled into fists as her jaw clenched.

But then she looked away snarling “Fine” before turning on her heel, tail swaying down.

They shared one last glance, backs turned before shadows consumed Scarlet’s vision, those heterchromic eyes and those folded ears being the last thing she saw before being swallowed up.

“You’ve really taught them some useless traditions...” Weaver's voice echoed while she trudged through the shadowy tendrils floating around her like restraints.

Head tilting up a blond girl’s smile flashed under her eyelids; *I wonder when I’ll see them again...* .

Induction day

Chapter Summary

Shadow Weaver's past is muddled but certainly full of misfortune and dark deeds.... So no wonder her closet full of skeletons is more akin to a mass grave....

Scarlet has been released from her punishment... Yet something is wrong, a frigid heavy coldness follows her wherever she goes and her head aches... So nothing too much out of the norm but why does Catra seem so, odd when seeing her? And where does she want to take Adora and her?

Chapter Notes

It's been a while again, this was actually supposed to come out a bit over a week ago but I was sick with a high fever for a while so I've been mostly laying in bed. But now that only one of my ears is ringing and I don't feel like I'm freezing when I'm actually burning up like a furnace here it is, last chapter of this prequal.

Enjoy and don't worry, I should be content enough with hove many chapters I have ready to start releasing chapters for the proper continuation of Fang's, Claw's and a girl with a sword during or a bit after Christmas.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Induction day

15 years before Thaymor, location, siege of Halfmoon

Brick wall shattering, shards of rock splattered in every direction as a maroon armored person erupted out of it with misty shadows

and crimson lighting exploding past. The arcs from that lightning scorched the walls of tens of houses in a row, shattering their windows as dust and smoke followed the stray bolts of electricity. Claws raked through the street, stone and concrete flying in every direction while C'yra screamed against gritted teeth, arms bulging and forcing her into a full stop.

Tens of drag lines littered the street as a single kneepad hit the ground, heart hammering against her chest while gasping for breath. *Where's Angella??? I have been fighting for days* -

A deep tearing cough dislodged something slimy and hot from her throat that she spat onto the dusty ground creating a wet spot in the middle of gray. A dark red gooey sludge stared back at the magicat. Blood, thick blood hung from her lower fang and lip drooping to the ground. Yellow spots shimmered in that crimson..... Back uncurling, her head craned back towards the darkened sky. Moons twinkled weakly behind gray and black clouds as flakes rained down on her smoking and smoldering city. They caught onto her hair but didn't melt like snow on her flush cheeks.

She caught one in her palm, it falling on the leather strap digging into her hand covered in dry blood and holding the sanguine plate protecting the back of her hand. It was ash which also covered the streets and rooftops. It was ash which was shot up when shells crackled and crumbled her castle. Its golden oval roof sliding down the wall tearing it asunder. The windy shockwave ruffled her mane like hair making her ears flap as a wave of dust swallowed the street. More pebbles and bricks rained down on the giant staircase behind her, bouncing down its steps as a door with half a lion's face fell off its hinges and crashed to the ground with a roaring creak.

C’yra couldn’t hear much fighting anymore, only the hollow shocks of artillery thudding against her feet and reducing her city to rubble..... The last of her people had probably already retreated into the tunnels, yet a tug at her heart made her look back. Why hadn’t she left yet? Why hadn't Micah already dragged Josephine, her mate, to the other side of the mountain? *Why haven’t you taken Halfmoons legacy and future to safety..* .. The gentle silky strings around her heart tugged again, pulling with panic in both directions while they constricted and squeezed inside of her chest.

“Why can I feel you coming.... Here?!” the magicat’s legs strained and trembled before her knees hit the ground again...

She felt hollow, the runestone had to have been moved already, its magic being the only thing keeping her going at this point. The green sigils on her dark red armor were dimming, the slim steel being deceptively durable and the magic coursing through it causing her to feel cold and heavy. Even so she hoped it’d last just a little longer as a wave of heat washed over her, the dimmed runes flickering on and off with a stuttered breath.

C’yra clenched her fist and roared. Green runes flared as she stood, and fire returned to her veins-

A silvery glint swished through the air, smoke trailing its descent before shattering a chimney as a chill ran down the queen's spine “h-how are you still-”

“It was presumptuous to believe something designed to hold a noble vampire would keep me still, not to mention one you clearly haven’t used before..... Isn’t it time to surrender? It’d be such a shame to see you just die here since no one’s coming to save you anymore” the masked woman mocked, hair afloat as red static surrounded her extended finger tips.

That wasn’t supposed to trap her, it was supposed to kill her.... C’yra thought back to when she’d snuck into the library back when her parents were still here just so she could be with Josephine. They’d read for hours while theorizing how to beat different monsters, time just flying back in those days.... But it seemed they’d been wrong.

“How disappointing” reverberated from under that dark red mask while crimson seared from its eye sockets and static bounced in-between the witches' fingers.

C’yra’s wide bloodshot eyes stared like daggers as that red filled her vision like tendrils shooting from the corners of her eyelids. The witches' movements slowed to a crawl but hands moved forward like snakes' heads striking and spewing their venom straight towards her. Lightning bounced through the air; shadow lances struck from the ground as every muscle in her body constricted and her eyelids fell shut.

A snow white magicat with golden eyes and black stripes on her skin smiled back, a small whining bundle tightly held to her chest. C'yra's lower lip quivered as she swallowed the cold heavy lump in her throat. *I’ve bought enough time* . Eyes snapped open a deep bestial roar rumbled throughout the entire kingdom as those red

rods smashed into the green fiery barrier projecting out of her armor.

Bones extended and snapped while the straps on her sanguine armor broke and with it the last strands of her sanity for one more time.... C'yra felt every band of muscle that tore before magic poured over her wounds like honey. A numbing cold settled as her teeth almost hatched into sharpened maulers while her fangs pushed outward-

Molten lava flashed through C'yra's nerves, right arm curling back in agony as skin scorched off in dark flakes crumbling into the air. Eyes almost scrunched completely shut she could only watch the sparks climb up her arm, slowly eating through her flesh as blue hollow outlining's of that same lightning showed the feline where it'd burn through her next. One of the now unfortunate side effects of the cat's eyestone's power was how it allowed her to visually project predictions of where something would be next... And to perceive information faster in use....

A blue outlining aimed straight into the middle of her right pupil as the electricity just kept bursting through the green shielding swirling around the queen. *DON'T COME HERE!* C'yra pleaded, hoping and begging her feelings would get through to her mate, *I'm sorry.....*

White filled her vision as it felt like a searing hot knife pierced her cranium through her eye, sending her to oblivion...

<<<<<<<

Shadow Weaver watched the once great magicat queen crash through flights of white marble stairs, tearing an upward crater through the stone. The magicat was still alive, fortunately, body convulsing and jittering on the ground as foam spilled out of her half-transformed mouth.

“All that power and you squander it on the useless.... Like the rest of your species in the end you’re nothing but rabid animals hiding yourselves and your knowledge like the selfish creatures you are..... How truly vexing....” she ranted to no one...

Hovering over the rubble Shadow Weaver ascended the wide stairs beside a giant broken castle door. She stared at the heap which had been this kingdoms greatest protector, personally having led the front line and ripped through so many of Hordak’s forces these past two days....

Yet with the overwhelming number of soldiers and Halfmoons' much smaller population this was, inevitable. Not to even mention the Horde lords' absurd amount of armor and artillery.... It was truly a shame to see such a highly magical kingdom reduced to ash like the gray flakes raining down around them as if it were a calm winter evening. Yet smoldering heat surrounded the two as the few giant runes left died out on the few castle walls still standing....

“You were as overconfident as Mystacor’s council, but do not worry, I will put all your people's knowledge to better use and your people well..... Hordak has plans for them” Shadow Weaver cocked her masked head before sighing.

“I’d ask you where Micah is but....” Weaver's head fell with a wistful gaze behind her....

She’d seen her former pupil around these past few days... And to say he hadn’t been happy to see her was an understatement. She hadn’t held it against him even when he’d come at her with the fury of a thousand suns but.... Looking to the sky, moonlight peaked past the clouds as regret seeped through her mind. How she wished he’d had the resolve to finish the spell of obtainment, *I should’ve waited a little longer before.... Or maybe-*

“ **NOOO!** ” someone shouted from a nearby rooftop, pushing a caped silvery armored individual away.

“You survived that did you?” Weaver drawled as a blond magicat in cracked armor launched forward as smoky shadows swirled around the individual behind him.

Blood seeped from his forehead before his form flickered and tore itself apart in lime colored sand. Three pairs of green eyes now glared at her midair as these golden armored people charged. With the swipe of one hand dark tendrils covered in red sparks shot out of the shadows below Weaver’s robes. *How foolish... They should've ran when they had the chance!*

Two managed to sidestep while one of his... Clones? Arms were cut off. Almost yellow dust exploded out of the severed

limbs “more illusions...” she muttered when the distinct sound of swirling air jettisoned behind her.

Smoky shadows rose, a darker copy of the silvery armored individual emerging an orb of what almost looked like moonlight in between his palms. This individual was an Eclipse, the silvery parts of his armor glowing brightly in the moonlight... He was much more powerful now that it was night than when she’d fought one last.... But the way his chest heaved, and plates looked to be falling off him.... The corner of Weaver’s mouth simply quirked in amusement.

The much more authentic copy of the blond magicat or that’s who Weaver presumed was the one wrapping pure golden moonlight around his palms bent his knees, ready to pounce for a suicide charge. That amount of power would probably obliterate the user on impact..... But she was beside C’yra, wouldn’t it-

“Murderer!” the blond magicat screamed as they flew towards her from both sides while the originals stayed back.

Oh.

The silvery orb sucked into the shadow's hands, claws now glowing brightly as they left white lines in the air. But Weaver just stood there, not lifting a finger. The long caped Eclipse moved first, probably thinking of countering whatever she was about to do, smoky knives being pulled from under his cape just under his knuckles.

Tsk

Shadow Weaver's form evaporated into darkness as the clones stopped just before impact "run prince Leo!" the Eclipse shouted, irises flaring white under his helmet.

Reappearing behind what constituted as the queen's royal guard, Shadow Weaver's head snapped towards the blond magicat who gritted his teeth and reached out with wide fearful eyes. But it was too late, Weaver's spindly fingers hovered over the Eclipse a neon greenish yellow magic circle forming while shadows wrapped around his armor.

"If I remember correctly, your sect was originally created during the vampiric war" Shadow Weaver chuckled darkly "maybe I'm already at the level of a progenitor"

The magic circle rigidly stopped spinning as it dilated on the person frozen in red static below the witch. All the smoke coming off his armor was sucked into Weaver's hand, runes on his plates glaring blue before even that was swept up into her arm and traveling even past that swirling into the witches chest. Before emerald green energy swam through his helmets eye holes and mouthpiece with one last ragged gasp for life.

The clothes and armor suddenly sank where his muscles had previously been until Shadow Weaver could feel the last drop of his magic and more disappear. With a relieved sigh a husk inside

of plated armor disturbed the ash covered ground with a heavy rattling thud. Hovering over the body she watched the prince dash over the last step with C'yra on his back.

That won't do , she thought, when the mirror image and the smoky clone stared her down from on top of the wide steps. Shadow Weaver shook her head-

Crimson plasma rocketed over her with a hail of green following it, obliterating a hole through the blond magicat's chest, sand pouring to the ground as he grasped at his missing stomach "those damn pests" a deep grainy voice growled out "they don't have the right sense to surrender to their betters, argh..... Such a primitive species, can't they see I'm bringing salvation to their caveman kingdoms...."

"With that I have to agree Lord Hordak, their resistance only brings them more pain yet...."

The Horde lord's heavy steppes crushed rocks like they weren't even there as he lowered his arm cannon with an agitated groan "where's the runestone user?"

Shadow Weaver simply pointed towards the castle "they've cornered themselves inside and no one's coming to their rescue, my preparations have made sure of that"

“Excellent, then we will march. MEN, forward! Subjugate them to the last specimen” he stomped forward, crushing a piece of sanguine armor under his boot while his same-colored cape flapped by his feet.

“Mhmm” Weaver murmured, a slight green glow catching her eye under some rubble in the crater the queen had made.

Bending down boney fingers brushed ash and stone off a green glow, like two eyes staring back at her dissipated from the dirty red metallic piece she picked off the broken steps.

The Fright zone, Black garnet room, 2 years and 2 weeks before Thaymor

Shadow Weaver held the M shaped dirty dark red object flipping it around in her hand, reminiscing of.... Simpler times.... Days when her power was overflowing, and her body wasn’t skin and bones. The still freshly devoured creature from a more ethereal realm in between worlds wrapping around her muscles and filling her empty spaces..... Solidifying and forcing her magical channels to bulge and enlarge.

“Ngh! Ghhh...”

But it wasn’t sustainable, the strength she’d wielded was fleeting, not even tweaking spells and scouring old tombs or raiding kingdoms for their knowledge had been enough. The absorption

spell simply had too much spillage, like trying to use a funnel on a river..... It all simply splattering around her, drenching her robes and forcing her to collect it with her hands.... And even back then she'd been able to do all of that without much issue... But prolonged use of dark magic....

"Arh... Agh!"

Weaver spun in place, the metal piece clinking onto the table as she swiped her palm over the green liquid in her cauldron. Its surface rippled and swirled, revealing a city shaped like a cone surrounded by calm waters with a single stone bridge connecting it to the continent. Wooden boats came and went with different insignias... A holy sword stabbing through a pointy eared ghouls' milky white skull being the most common nowadays.

"Tsh! A! ffff...."

"Focus on the cool flow that comes up" Weaver instructed to the blond gritting her teeth with sigils burning brightly on her arms and shoulders.

"I-I'll try... B-but I s-still d-don't feel a-anything"

She let out a sigh, finger swirling around the contents of the cauldron. A subtle change in the Salinean waters, hunters had been seen more and more with the mermaid sigil lessening year by year. The new regent who surprisingly wasn't the princess's

father was doing a piss poor job of keeping their kingdom in shape. The cracks had been showing ever since the self-proclaimed empress of the seas died mysteriously. A blessing for the Horde for certain but the rumors around her death were, odd.

Death by her own potential, magical overload, her body apparently after years giving out..... But there hadn't to Weaver's observations been any signs. No weakened control, hell even weeks before her death it was believed her simply being in a bad mood had caused storms and wild waves over twenty-five meters tall.... So, her power was certainly not diminished and then there was the fact the king had disappeared.....

Simply the fact the Hordes destroyers couldn't leave far from the coast only days before she'd supposedly died without risking turning into what Shadow Weaver could only translate into a dissected fish didn't support the royal courts claim. It wasn't unheard of when the sea empress was still alive for ships to return to the Hordes harbors repainted in only and strictly the former crewmen's blood.

Like a ghost story they'd purposefully floated back drenched in crimson.... Maybe she was why Hordak had started focusing on his flying contraptions even more frivolously back then... Coughing into her hand Shadow Weaver chuckled. It didn't really matter anymore though she simply wished the current regent would do a better job at helping Mermista govern. She could only shield their weaknesses from the rest of the force majors for so long before....

Weaver turned and palm waved over the cauldron as only empty bubbles returned "that's enough Adora" with the snap of her

fingers the sigils died down as the blond visibly sunk into her chair with a relieved sigh.

"I-I'm sorry ma'am, I-I still don't feel anything...." arm behind her back the witch hovered over, trailing her ring finger over the now silvery dust resting on the Blond's shoulder before flicking it aside.

"Do not be too disheartened, I wasn't expecting anything with this test" that wasn't completely true, she'd wished enough strain on her channels would force them open yet..... It seemed as if not only was something almost most certainly blocking her.... But Adora's body could take a monstrous amount of magic into itself....

Arms up Adora grasped at the air, feeling a surge of tension leave through her arms and shoulders while Weaver looked deep in thought. The tips of her fingers trailed the jagged pages of an intricately ornate book. Adora chewed on the inside of her cheek before pulling down the sleeves of her white cadet issued T-shirt after brushing off the cool gray sand which magnetically shuffled into a pile on the ground.

Adora blinked, magic was so, weird, and the thought of her having some hidden potential was enticing yet somewhat frightening. No matter what Weaver did nothing seemed to ever happen. Not that she doubted her mentor, but these tests simply didn't do anything. Her shoulders fell with a heavy exhale, yet her gaze fleeted towards the red object resting on the table.

Adora’s fist balled by her side, if she really had power, she’d use it to protect the people around her and bring peace to Etheria. But in the meanwhile “ummm, what’s that?” Adora asked, eyes glued to the face? Ornament? Thing?

“Hmmm? Ah, that... It’s an old dead relic from a selfish civilization”

“So, it isn’t dangerous?”

“No Adora it is not, now you’ll be late for your studies if you keep focusing on useless things” Shadow Weaver lazily waved to the door.

“C-can I, have it?” Adora stuttered, watching her commanding officer hesitantly while her fingers fiddled together behind her back.

Weaver suddenly looked at her with an unreadable expression. Adora shuffled in place, standing a bit straighter as an electric hum swept up the head piece with a subtle motion of gray fingers. Weaver soon hovered up to her and brushed a couple strands of hair off her glistening forehead. A coolness pressed into it, around it while brushing over her temples and curving down her cheeks.

“There it, fits, if you’d switch from white to more Horde appropriate colors....”

“I’m happy with what I have now” Adora grinned even if this thing felt uncomfortable before bowing “thank you, I’ll be on my way”

“You do that, remember not to slack off and let Catra’s bad habits influence you too much”

The blond simply nodded letting the door slide shut behind her before grabbing the almost M shaped face ornament off her and rubbing at her temples “maybe it’ll fit either of them better...” Adora murmured while imagining how it’d look like as a small smile formed over her lips.

West wing, mess hall quadrant

Scarlet’s feet dragged through the stale gray halls, people passing by in a blur their mouths moving, words coming out jumbled as the sickly green lights buzzed above. A finger twitched as if something had zapped it, the only thing feeling real for the moment as otherwise she simply pulled this hollow husk forward, nose strictly pointed towards the ground.

Emptiness swirled where her heart should be, a hole, a void swallowing any light leaving her numb and heavy like hundreds of invisible chains wrapped around her and sunk into her shadow. Scarlet’s body suddenly jerked as some humanoid Etherian narrowed their eyes at her.

“Ah, sorry....” she exhaled as whoever’s shoulder she’d just bumped into scoffed before jogging after their friends.

They laughed, some even glanced back clearly looking down on her. Yet her eyes stared forward while turning the corner, no usual spark of anger escaping from the pit in her chest. Only red seared behind her eyelids, chains and dark gray walls.... Then an electric hum with distant words she couldn’t quite comprehend, a threat? Gripping her forehead, *that, place?* Faded and slipped from her grasp, sinking to the back of her mind replaced by..... Nose scrunched a mix of chemicals and cleaning detergent burnt through her nostrils. Scarlet blinked, eyes darting around, that lingering cold replaced by the taste of those crummy dirt dry blocks of protein and whatever else they jam packed into these things flying to the forefront of her mind.

“Blegh...” she almost gagged if not for her stomach rumbling....

Scarlet swallowed with a grimace that soon faded away into indifference. That was just what the Horde was, same thing every day, same motions and same activities. Large open double doors slid to the sides in the distance, people talking loudly over each other echoing out with cutlery clinking on plates as three cadets stepped inside, the noises muffling as the doors slid back closed.

Even if it sounded like everyone was excited and energetic, laughing and yelling... It made her wonder if any of them had ever actually eaten normal food. Ration bars only switched between colors with barely any taste change and yet everyone seemed content when, for example, yellow ones came in for the fourth time in a single month. They said it was rare or there

weren't enough resources to make them every day which made it a treat for them but.... She had to wonder.

Day in day out they learnt battle tactics, how to use rifles, hand to hand combat and if not that then how to take care of their equipment. The only reason she thought they even learnt how every known species of Etherian's body functioned was to know how to deal with them on the battlefield. Then there were general classes like math, but much less emphasis was put on them since it wasn't physical... She'd once questioned Weaver why some classes were considered so much more important though... The only answer she'd received was those other classes only existed so the common soldier wouldn't be a complete idiot and so she wouldn't have to spoon feed information to them. She was told not to care since she was destined for more than the common ingrate.

"Come on, just loan us your ration pass, they'll believe it if you just say you lost yours, but us.... Well, you know"

"Guys I can't, you didn't even give me back last month's pass, they'll think somethings up and what will I eat if-" two boys caged in a dirty blond haired.... *Kyle? Where's Rogelio or?*

"That's not how I remember it, we returned yours.... Besides did you really need it?"

"I think that's enough, rat" heads turned they both blinked.

“What did you say?”

“You heard me” Scarlet answered, rolling back her shoulders and going through the motions.....

They stared her down and stepped forward as Scarlet arched a brow. Eyes scanned her up and down, chests puffed out before they just scoffed simply passing her with a sneer. *Empty threats and showboating...* . Scarlet sighed indignantly, head falling back down.

“T-thank you, I didn-”

“You know you could just throw a punch or tell them off, most people are all bark....” Kyle just scratched the back of his neck with a meek smile.

“I don’t.... You never know you know? Risking getting beaten to a pulp when I can still-”

“Whatever..... Take the advice or don’t, I sure couldn’t live like you....” again Kyle simply chuckled awkwardly as door hydraulics churned, the mess hall chatter hitting her like the glare of the morning sun when she’d just woken up....

With a flinch she kept walking, Kyle sauntering close as they weaved past tables and other cadets with trays in hand. Shuffling

forward in a long line it didn’t take long for a single gray rectangle to be slapped onto her plate. Scarlet just stared at it emptily, snatching a glass from a nearby rack before pressing it into a switch pouring water into it.

“You're not getting juice? They barely ever serve it” Kyle cocked his head.

“Because it’s a poor excuse for a juice....” whatever that orange liquid was, tasted sour and salty.... Like everything else here, it was probably just jampacked with different supplements....

“I think it’s pretty good, certainly haven’t heard the others complain about it”

“That’s just because you don’t know any better.....” Scarlet grumbled with a look of pity, *maybe it’s better this way.....* . She thought as the blond boy waved to a distant table where a small group with a certain feline picking her nails in boredom pushed her knees up against the edge of the table.

“Grrrprf” Rogelio’s throat and the underside of his chin vibrated.

“Hmpf? Kyle what- look whose fiiiinally back, maybe you can finally relieve me from Catra duty....” Lonnie’s arm hung over the back of her chair as she turned, crumbs of a gray ration bar littering her cheeks.

“Wha.....”

“Lonnie you incomprehensibly idiotic bastard, is there only dirt in-between your ears? She asked you to hold a seat for her and nothing else” Catra flicked whatever crap there’d been under her nail to the side as her lips curled exposing teeth.

“Haha ~ sure buddy, why don’t you stuff that ration bar so you can stop blabbering or are you going to find another rat from the trash to eat?” Lonnie barbed, chin high up while sitting widely.

Scarlet simply sighed, closing her eyes and setting down her tray before straightening out her back with a tired groan. Catra’s mouth moved to probably bite back, yet her jaw stuttered as Scarlet frowned at the gray block of nutrients in her hand.... Knees dipping below the table Catra’s chairs front legs clattered as she sat straight.

“What? Cat got yo-”

“Shut. Up, I don’t care, ok?”

Eyes bore into her as the gray block crumpled onto her tongue like sand, yet this somehow probably had less taste than even that..... “what?” Scarlet asked, cheeks full and crumbs raining back onto her plate.

“W-what? Nothing” Catra stuttered before chewing down on her own block of cement.

“Your staring” Scarlet corrected while deciding to shove the entire ration bar into her mouth, get this tasteless thing over with....

“Am not, I’m just surprised you didn’t go find Adora first” the feline quipped, elbow on the table.

“What’s that sup-” she caught herself as clawed fingers barely peaked from under the table.

Scarlet frowned and leaned over whispering “nothing happened, you should know, same old same old”

Now she frowned, annoyance radiating off her “two weeks isn’t nothing or same old same old, but sure I’ll pretend you don’t look like you’re about to pass out any moment, I’ll just laugh at you when you crumple like Kyle in CQC training”

Eyes scrunched shut a sharp pain stabbed through her skull momentarily before kicking Catra in the shin under the table “I’ve been gone for like five days max, you're blowing this out of proportions for no reason” Catra simply stared at her, no emotion displayed on her features.

“Then what happened? And why where you there?”

“What sort of question is that?? You already know the answer to both”

“Humor me”

“Fine, I lost control, and she did what she always does before throwing me with the other rejects not learning magic properly” Scarlet answered, arms crossed but.... The words somehow rang, hollow... As if they weren't her own or incomplete.....
Though these feelings were fleeting yet, something wriggled in her mind-

“Ah!” Scarlet’s hand shuddered as if she was pinched tens of times, making her quickly shake it “what’s up with today....”

“Fine, whatever, let's just get out of this dump-” Catra’s ears suddenly perked up with a worrying grin following it “well if your fine, then you wouldn’t mind sneaking outside in the neeeext, twenty so minutes?”

“Don’t we have class?”

“Not for the next two hours, the teachers have some meeting thingy majing, who really knows” she shrugged.

Scarlet simply deadpanned not sure if she should believe her.... Not to mention why the courtyard?

“I’m saying it now, you're gonna get caught, besides where would you even get credits from? Because I'm like ninety percent sure they won’t trade whatever trash you’ve either dug up or well, stolen” Lonnie butted in, steel cup to her mouth while side eyeing the green lizard grumbling something to the blond.

Catra rolled her eyes and scoffed “who would even care if we were there? And you don’t need to know how I do shit” she continued pointedly.

“What exactly are you trying to drag me into?”

“Hihi, let me show you?” Scarlet just shook her head...

“Look I’m tired, I think I’m just gonna lay down for the next two hours”

“Nooo, come on, it’ll be fun, we’ll snatch up Adora on the way, I know she won’t say no” the vampire managed out an exasperated grumble when a hand settled itself on her shoulder.

“Say no to what?” a familiar voice asked, making Scarlet rub the bridge of her nose.

Zap

“Agh” she almost bit her tongue as crimson static bounced in-between her fingers “I guess we’re going...” Catra jumped out of her chair with a faint giggle, snatching even her empty tray as a very confused blond sat down.

“What’s up with her?”

“I have no idea....” Scarlet answered, intently staring at her hand with narrowed confused eyes.

10 minutes or so later

Jogging down the jagged hall behind a swishing tail Scarlet wondered how it seemed the two of them were so powerless when it came to the feline’s antics. She simply flashed a fanged smile, body almost coiling around while softly bumping into them. It was stupid really.....

Lights flickered above as an electric buzz coursed through lamps, green zapping at the air from exposed wiring as she bumped into Catra’s back. Tail brushing her hip an arm extended while she

peaked her head around the corner as the exposed wire crackled again, dimming them for a moment.

Scarlet flinched at the sound, hands suddenly trembling with a stuttered exhale as a cold washed over her. Images of a dark figure came into view as Catra scurried hunched over around the corner, claws fiddling with something. The vampire closed her eyes only for that shadow to loom over her as her limbs locked on a table before red static came into view, that zapping now turned into crackling-

“Hey? Everything ok?” sucking in sharply Scarlet’s eyes darted around, only to land on her clenched fists in front of her.

“Y-yeah, just a bit tired” she lied, unclasping her hands and focusing on the soothing warmth gently holding onto her shoulder.

There was nothing to explain, Adora would only needlessly worry about something so irrelevant. So, all she did was put her hand on hers before peaking over her shoulder “really, it was nothing” the blonds breath stuttered ever so slightly through her nose, yet she smiled back, irises almost graying just a little when something akin to keys turning in a lock suddenly clacked.

“Hah! Come on” Catra waved as a gust of air fluttered her ears and stung Scarlet’s now rosy cheeks.

Slinking through Adora barely didn’t close it, leaving a tiny metal sheet in-between. No one ever used these backdoors leading almost straight into a concrete wall with razor wiring on top. But if someone did, they’d find another way to sneak back inside. Years of living in what was essentially a maze of steel and machinery with almost nothing to do with your free time had led to a lot of exploration unsurprisingly.

Toys had been replaced by crude metal objects and forests and wilderness had transformed into a steel jungle filled with bots and guards for animals while vents and tubes became rocks, rivers and vines. Even outside there were bright yellow lights beaming down on the main roads. Soldiers clad in gray and green walked past periodically while they crouched under and over pipes in tight alleyways.

The dark gray walls brushed against their shoulders squeezing them in as light barely spilled inside in the distance. This far away from the forges there was a frigid chill in the air making the two shudder from time to time. But some of the pipes and walls were still scolding hot. A general rule was to not touch anything if it was making noises, especially if it sounded like something was coursing through it.

“We’re here” Catra suddenly whispered while hopping over a crooked looking pipe and slinking into the light.

Arms on her sides she grinned “this isn’t the courtyard?” Adora piped up with crossed arms but a knowing smile.

“Nope, what did you think I was gonna say where we were actually going in the middle of the mess hall?”

“Lonnie seemed to know”

“That’s because she’s a nosey bitch”

“Catra...” Adora reprimanded.

“Yeah, whatever but she’s still nosey..... Let's just go, we have under two hours before Weaver starts hounding after us.....” the feline sighed, shoulders drooping with her mouth in a line before turning on her heel.

Rows of lampposts buzzed and beamed down on half tents littering the streets. The bright red fabric blocking the few droplets of water and other darker liquids from tainting the boxes below. Instead, it lightly splattered on the tents, a few smaller droplets splashing onto the road where engines hummed, and puddles of darkened liquids rippled.

Scarlet shuffled close to the blond on instinct while Catra sauntered forward through the group of guards and force captains as a skiff hovered past. The soldiers on top dangled their feet, helmets off and bottles in hand almost just lying on the deck. Behind it a small hover truck followed, the entire street seeming filled to the brim with vehicles and even tanks.

“What’s going on?” Scarlet murmured.

“I heard we just conquered a small kingdom, maybe their celebrating?” Adora answered distantly, wide blue eyes glinting in the skiff's rear lights.

“Their bringing back stuff they found and since we’re closest to the city border”

“We’re the first to get to buy whatever they took” the corner of Catra’s mouth quirked up as she peaked over her shoulder at her.

“Wait, is that allowed? Aren’t these resources supposed to be used by everyone?”

“Ehhh, no one really seems to care if it isn’t something important, I think...” Catra shrugged as Adora pursed her lips looking vexed.

“They shouldn’t just waste resources on selfish reasons....”

“I think it helps with morale” Scarlet noted, pointing at a one-eyed octopus woman surrounded by others like her throatily laughing while they poured down some foamy liquid down their gullets as she haggled over something by a booth, boot on top of one of the crates clinking with bottles.

Two pointed ears perked, swiveling forward as Catra's tail swirled excitedly. *Oh no* "where are you go-" Adora tried, reaching past Scarlet. But she was already gone, stalking through the crowd past a green armored lizard dangling a big purple sizzling frog over his open maw. Catra seamlessly slinked through the crowd, barely touching anyone in her stalk before straightening out.

She spun to be back-to-back to what must have been Octavia making it look like she was interested in something in the booth opposite of the octopus woman's. Hand over her mouth she hugged her waist before just walking away. *Huh?* She'd barely brushed against the woman without antagonizing her or even getting a reaction...

"T-that umm, was anticlimactic" Adora pretty much sighed in relief to Scarlet's dry chuckle.

"Well look at what I found" the feline suddenly popped up beside them with a small pouch in her palm as Adora jumped back, hands behind her lower back with a squeak.

"W-what was that? A-are you ok?" Scarlet and Catra stared wide eyed as the blond precariously straightened out, patting her pants while looking off to the side.

"Y-yeah, oh look at that booth, why are they hanging up frogs and, rats?" Adora blinked, eyes narrowing like she wasn't sure what she was seeing.

“Oh no, no, no, no, you did not get scared just now, what are you hiding?” Catra grinned while pocketing the pouch.

“I’m not hiding anything, like whaaat? Pfft, no way” Adora nervously smiled, hands up and open.

Catra’s tail swished from side-to-side eyes suddenly hyper focused as she lowered “oh no you don’t” Scarlet softly yanked the back of her shirt collar “there are too many people around, your gonna draw too much attention” especially since they weren’t just any cadets..... She didn’t need some overzealous instructors trying to get on Weavers good side by snitching on them...

“Now if you two want to have your fun we should probably get going”

“W-where the hell is my other pouch???!” a familiar voice suddenly bellowed “I know I took it with me!” Octavia’s tentacles lashed at the air irritatedly as her head frantically snapped around a glinting glare in her eye.

“Oh shit” Catra squeakily giggled as Scarlet pushed her forward with an exasperated sigh while Adora pushed them both, peaking over her shoulder and chuckling dryly.

But Scarlet couldn’t help the small smile tugging at the corners of her mouth as they speed walked away “hey watch where you're going” some one eyed purple man? Growled.

“Sorry!” Adora waved before draping her arms around their shoulders and settling her weight there “so, what are we doing here again?”

“Other than pickpocketing Octavia” Scarlet added.....

“Oh, please like that wasn’t absolutely hilarious, I mean did you see her face?? I know I just had it, wheeere did it go??” Catra’s head wobbled from side to side, eyes wide while making an exaggerated impression of the octopus lady.

“You really hate her” Scarlet stated with an amused grin as Adora snorted “don’t derail the conversation you gremlin”

“Whaaat? Why would I even do that? I think you're imagining it” Catra said with half lidded eyes.

“Pfft, yeah right, like you wouldn't do something like that just to gloat” the blond said, fingers entangled and ruffling her wild mane.

“Dumb assess why do you think we’re here?” Catra asked, nudging the Blond's ponytail.

“To antagonize random people?”

“To stare at random stuff we can’t afford?”

Catra deadpanned as they stared at her with cocked heads “ugh..... Just keep walking, I wanna show you idiots something...”

So, they walked following the column of skiffs and small cargo freighters hauling material. Guards, soldiers and force captains of various species shouting up at the ones hitching a ride in good spirits. Sometimes even jumping on and looking around before handing credits to the soldier just sitting there.

They returned to the street often with different ornaments, clothes or even a box full of small dead animals in hand before either disappearing into the crowd or returning to a tent nearby. Rifles, crates of plasma canisters, clips, mags, armor and ration packets were traded by hand among other gadgets to the second column heading in the opposite direction, away from the core of the Fright zone.

Finally stepping past one of the last steel buildings another set of tall steel walls faced them in the distance. Giant spotlights glared down even on the inside of the walls where normally there’d be large open space for drills to be performed. But now under the dark cloud's booths and tents littered the yard with even what seemed to be a force commander according to his pin considering purchases.

Brightened blades and maces hummed with inscribing's glowing in racks and Scarlet's mouth suddenly watered. Not that she could even drain those objects, but the fragrance fleeted past her nose. As they passed, she stared at them longingly only for her attention to snap as they came to a halting stop.

"We're here, whatcha ya think?" Adora and Scarlet just stared at the assortment of different weapons, armor and clothes with wide eyes.

"Why are there so many different kinds of swords?" the blond asked, finger stuttering before she touched a blade.

Scarlet scratched her chin, eyeing some gloves and jackets while narrowing her eyes "how much does this stuff cost?"

"More than a couple cadets can cough up" a gray bearded burly ogre said, roughly clearing his throat.

"Hmmm, I wouldn't be so sure about that, see we have" Catra stepped in but quickly stopped as her nose scrunched while digging in her pockets and pulling out three golden rectangles plus the pouch she'd stolen "sixty credits"

The man's brows rose, his almost fully yellow eyes widening slightly "well then-" he started before his nose made this sound

like a woodchipper as he spat something black into a bucket full of..... Dark tar?

"You may buy regular clothes or weapons, everything else is sadly out of your price range" his bloated stomach bounced as bellowing laughter reverberated from his chest to Catra's deep frown.

Catra grumbled something under her breath, but Scarlet had expected this to be the case. Cadets weren't paid and the only things they could even sell was equipment, but it couldn't be anything serialized so meds were more reliable... Even then the amount of actually useful things that they actually didn't need or wouldn't need in the future was exceedingly small.

Scarlet sighed but kept eyeing the things on display "so umm, what happens if you can't sell all this stuff, you just gonna hoard it?" the gray ogre shifted in his seat, scratching his beard and putting down a half-eaten ration bar.

"Of courshe not, all of tchis is just ay, firsth served firsth buyh shitchouation" he gulped, finally swallowing before taking a swig of a canteen "the rest will either be smelted or taken into use after, eeevaluation" he explained while side eyeing the blond who looked starry eyed.

Nodding Scarlet strode over pressing her shoulder into Adora's who only hummed in response "see something you like?"

“Huh? I-I'm not sure” she chewed on her lip and stared at the jackets.

Black, gray, white and red were the colorings to choose from, some with fur and others without sleeves but Adora seemed to stare at something specific. Scarlet quickly grabbed the bright red jacket with sleeves that only went over your biceps with a lot of space for broad shoulders.

“How much is this?” Scarlet asked while pressing it over Adora before spinning her around and doing the same.

“Thirty-five credits”

“Really?” Catra arched a brow with crossed arms “for a single jacket? Wasn’t this found?”

“It’s made out of good fabric” he pointed out.

“I don’t need it; we still haven’t gotten anything for induction day-”

“No, we’ll get it, here” Catra smacked down four golden rectangles with symbols printed onto them.

“But we won’t get anything for twenty-five credits, will we?” Scarlet and Catra just shrugged at that, they didn’t really need anything since they’d gathered some ration bars and still had a few energy bars left. It’d be enough like always.

“Doubtfully.... Buuut” the gray ogre suddenly said roughly before standing up and pulling out an almost half emptied bottle “if you give me the rest of your credits, I’ll throw this in”

A tall green bottle swirled with liquid on the table and Catra eyed it precariously, brows knitting together “sixty percent ALCO? What is this?”

The ogre huffed mouth forming into a smirk “it’ll make your induction day more, special, though I do recommend sharing it equally between the three of you. Unless you want to wake up in a dumpster tomorrow” he chuckled as a sour stench wafted making Scarlet pinch her nose. *What the hell?.* ...

The trio eyed each other, and the Blond's mouth opened when the pouch dropped onto the table “we’ll take that too” Catra grinned as a throaty laugh reverberated from the gray ogre's chest.

“That’s what I like to hear” he bellowed out as Adora and Scarlet glanced at each other with a groan.....

“Catra...”

“Catra...” the feline just snatched the bottle with a feral toothy smile.

“You're so, so spontaneous sometimes...” Adora murmured though the way she hugged the jacket made Scarlet visibly relax.

“Now you can’t say I never get you anything”

“Y-you used our credits and give me that”

“Nooo, you're not throwing it away!” Catra held it close shielding the bottle from Adora’s protective nature.

Scarlet stopped momentarily as Adora got the feline in a headlock and stumbled beyond the tent “that bottle looked expensive”

He just shrugged “I need to stop drinking anyway before my liver explodes, might as well give my last one to some spunky cadets with bright futures” she had to wonder if any warnings were needed, *Weaver would want that.....* Tell him if he lied or whatever was in that drink hurt Adora she’d.....

Weaver would want that... .

Nodding she stepped outside rubbing at her eyes as a wave of dull aches swept through her head. For a moment images of a dark figure hovering over her fleeted, yet she couldn't again put her finger on it. Maybe it was an old memory? *Did I hit my head???* Scarlet questioned as her vision blurred and red flashed. Shadows closed in like arms lashing at her with a frigid cold accompanying it, they strangled her entire bod-

"Scar?"

"H-huh?" blue eyes stared back, and she blinked with her heart in her throat. The shadows were gone almost like they'd retreated in the face of, her...

"You look pale again, seriously I'm worried..."

"It's nothing, where's?"

"She's staring at some big blue monster carcass, their removing It's horns" the blond answered, pursing her lips while narrowing her eyes at the ground before determination surged into those bright blue irises.

"Come on, let's go" Adora quickly covered Scarlet's shoulders with her new somehow already warm jacket before sweeping up her hand and pulling her forward away from the stinging cold as puffs of mist shot past their lips.

Getting pulled through the crowds, Scarlet tightly held onto the collar of Adora's new jacket, eyes transfixed on the lines her shoulders made through that white fabric. Like a lead tank people parted before the blond and even if it was just enough for them to pass. She couldn't help but scurry as close as possible....

People were whispering around them, talking and laughing with each other yet, somehow... It felt as if hundreds of eyes were on her, like everyone was glancing their way and chuckling. As if they were commenting on how weak and pathetic she was for needing help to walk forward. Almost like there were eyes in every shadow piercing her with their icy glares.

Scarlet's breath stuttered as she tried to steel herself... But ever since Weaver had let her go it was as if this cold had followed her everywhere.... Zapping the strength out of her limbs and dousing the furnace in her chest leaving only embers of her ego and rage.... Yet warmth radiated in front of her, and as clawed hands pushed her forward again it spread across her shoulders.

This time it didn't take even ten minutes to get back to that alleyway they'd come through, hopping over pipes and avoiding the heated walls. But this time they turned and climbed the jagged walls, Adora's handheld grappling hook swishing by as Catra effortlessly pulled herself up. Scarlet sucked in a sharp breath before doing the same. But her much more forceful way of dragging herself up made the rusting steel crumple under the force she used. A plate slid off screws and all, but Scarlet's grip held as she hung there sighing.

It was unfair how well Catra balanced herself, even now she could see those ears flutter as a yellow eye proudly gleamed down at her, yet her tail was deadly still. Eyebrows knitted together they kept going, climbing and climbing until the ground seemed to be getting smaller.

Lights blinked red and green on the distant rooftops deeper in the Fright zone and Scarlet pulled herself over the edge plopping back first into the cool rooftop. Gray clouds hung above yet a couple holes formed to reveal, nothing. No stars or even faint moonlight.... It was always cloudy above the Fright zone and the only light provided here was from buildings or industry unlike.....

It was probably because of the tens of forges spewing darkened smoldering smoke into the sky she thought when her black canvas was suddenly filled with an upside-down fanged grin. Catra swirled the bottle she'd bought excitedly making Scarlet push herself up with her elbows.

The feline giggled before dropping down and crossing her legs as a blond hair poof peaked over the edge "so what do you think this is?" Scarlet simply shrugged squinting at the text on the back.

"He did say to share it or to wake up in a dumpster the next morning?"

"Is this really a good idea?" Adora crossed her arms before Scarlet's shoulder pushed into hers.

“What? Are you scared of the only other thing we have the chance to drink?” Catra teased, hooking her arm around the red eyed girls shoulder to lightly run her claws over Adora’s who slapped it away before snatching the bottle.

“Hey!”

The cork spun open and Adora pressed the mouth of the bottle to her lips before almost flipping it around. Her eyes visibly flinched with the first gulp, veins popping on her neck before she coughed and hit her chest with heavy thuds.

“*Ough!* I-it tastes like disinfectant smells!” she raucously coughed as Scarlet rubbed her back tentatively.

Catra’s nose scrunched before she pinched it and took a swig of her own. Tears formed at the corners of her eyes, but she didn’t spit it out, only coughing before wiping her mouth “h-how could he drink this stuff?? It’s not even good, oh shit how do I get the taste out of my mouth???” she whined but held the bottle out to her.

Scarlet hesitantly took it before just staring and glancing at the two others now calming down “welp here goes nothing” the liquid felt thick on her tongue, warm even as an intense taste almost burnt when her mouth filled.

“Swallow it, don’t keep it in your mouth” Adora said as Scarlet’s cheeks bloated making her need two big gulps to get it all down.

“For Hordak's sake, what the hell is this???” she grimaced, putting the bottle down in the middle of them.

“You think we got scammed?”

“Probably, but that’s what we get for letting your impulsive ass hold on to our credits” Adora pointed out with a playful grin.

The feline's hair furled as she narrowed her eyes “watch the bottle” Scarlet simply noted only to be climbed over.

Adora didn’t have time to crawl away as she was ferociously pounced on and wrestled to the ground, only the vampire was quickly swept in as Catra’s stomach squished into her cheek. With a frown she fell into the Blond who snorted out “oh you think you can win this?!” as Catra cackled above them.

Scarlet’s fingers quickly did a grabby motion and Catra must’ve noticed because of the over dramatically shocked expression painting her features “friendly fire!”

“Oh, oh no, no YOU dragged me into this!” Catra squirmed and flailed as she cackled while being pulled down with oh such mighty protests.

For who knows how long this continued, time and responsibility having been forgotten. The feline plopped in-between them chest rising and falling as if she'd run a marathon. Knees folded sideways Adora leaned on her arm, hair poof broken and strands of gold sticking to her forehead. Her fingers gingerly ran over the feline's scalp whose head now neatly rested in Adora's lap who laid hers on Scarlet's shoulder with a giggle.

The generator beside them thrummed, pulses of hot air being pushed around them as it again whirred to life. Scarlet's head felt oddly calm like thoughts had been washed away fully immersing her in the moment as she massaged one of the calves of the legs sprawled over her lap.

Claws suddenly clinked on glass trying to reach for the bottle again. Scarlet simply exhaled softly, too busy being captivated by the rosy color spread over the bridge of Adora's nose which almost flowed into pools on her cheeks.

Two wide blue oceans suddenly stared up at her, those pink lips forming into a bubbly smile that shot something warm through the vampire's heart. She couldn't help but brush those golden strands off the Blond's face, hooking them behind her reddening ear. Scarlet's breath hitched as Adora leaned into her arm with a giggle and blew into it but then frowning as it didn't make any noise.

"Having trouble there Blondie?" the aforementioned blonde just stuck out the tip of her tongue at her before pressing it into the vampires wrist.

“You’re so disgusting” Scarlet chuckled but didn’t pull away as Adora tried to blow again....

“You know it isn’t so bad when you can’t taste anything anymore” Catra said, balancing the bottle on her stomach.

Adora just snorted “a little like when you licked a baton, you couldn’t talk properly for the whole day”

“IT WAS SHINY, and it wasn’t even on!”

“S-still!” Scarlet giggled, holding onto her stomach which constricted from all the laughter “w-why would you ever do that” she doubled over as Catra grumbled, starting to roll over out of their laps.

“Nooo!”

“Nooo! Just stay here, it’s ok, you can lick all the batons you want” Scarlet cooed as they flipped her back over.

“Besides how can I give you this if you just roll away?” Adora asked, arm behind her back and pulling something out.

She suddenly held a dark red almost M shaped object in her hand placing it on top of Catra's forehead who scrunched her nose "what is that?"

"A mask, I think, come on try it"

"Yeah, yeah" she groaned while fitting it on her face.

"Let me help" Scarlet mused at the feline.

"I got it"

Sighing she brushed some hair out of the way letting Catra fit it properly "do you like it?"

"Yeah, I guess it's ok..." she murmured, shaking her head to see if it'd fall off as she almost shyly looked away.

"Happy induction day!" Adora hooked her arm around Catra's shoulders pulling her into her chest.

Catra didn't squirm for once which only made the blond squish her tighter "it looks great on you" Scarlet added with a half-lidded smile.

Her face hid itself even more into the blonds embrace with a grumble after that "w-wait, if I got the jacket and you got the mask...." Adora turned with a mortified look "I'm sorry, I couldn't find anything I thought you'd like *hic*" tears brimmed at the corners of her eyes filled with hurt.

"Hey, it's ok, I didn't get either of you anything either so"

"B-but you where-"

"No buts, we've shared a few ration bars or energy bars every year until now, besides do you think I'd be mad over something like this when we can barely get our hands on normal supplies?" the two others just glanced at each other suddenly pulling on the collars of their shirts exposing their necks with tilted heads.

Scarlet's eyes went wide as they both just stared at her with relaxed expressions, more hair spilling from Adora's ponytail brushing against her neck and brow. Catra's eyes darted to the side, but she kept glancing at the completely frozen vampire whose lower lip curled inwards as saliva gathered under her tongue.

"W-what are you guys doing?" Scarlet asked, heat surging up to her gums "y-you shouldn't do that..." she continued palm now covering her mouth with a shameful glance at the ground.

“We can hide it from Weaver, and you need it, so just ask any time...” Adora explained, shuffling even closer as a hand brushed over hers.

Scarlet’s eyes darted down as a clawed hand settled on her leg “we’ve said this before, but you don’t need to let yourself get to the brink before.... You know, so consider this your present, maybe this won’t be like pulling teeth anymore....” Catra quipped with a look Scarlet didn’t recognize.

Her eyelids drooped but stayed just open as a thumb rubbed lazy circles into her ankle. It was like tension just evaporated from the feline's now slightly pinkish features “we’re in this together remember?” Adora added “you’d do the same for us in your position” she continued, dull nails lightly scratching the back of Scarlet’s neck.

The vampire's heart hammered against her ribs, and she hesitated, hand twitching as she looked from one to the other. Fangs growing, she inched forward as the Blond's brows jumped slightly “your eyes...” she murmured craning her neck only for Adora to let out a muffled stuttering gasp when Scarlet lunged forward.

“Mhmpf! Mmm.....” a soft open-mouthed heavy exhale escaped against the vampire’s tongue as she lightly held onto the back of the Blond’s neck.

Adora tightly clutched onto her shoulders as their lips mashed together, pupils widened as she eased into it suddenly

reciprocating and almost pushing the vampire over..... Until they reluctantly separated. Their chests were heaving, and Scarlet still felt the lingering pressure that'd been on her lips. A thumb suddenly ran over her bruised lower lip, and she couldn't breathe as Adora stared at it with hardened intent.

An abrupt shift by their feet pulled them both out of this trance that'd consumed their attention, almost as if the entire world had disappeared, her senses being just full of the blond so overwhelmingly. Catra stuttered in place, hands trembling as raw emotion reflected in her eyes.

"I-I, I t-thin-" she tried to look away, confusion and panic seemingly bubbling to the surface.

Trying to rise Scarlet quickly yanked her by the wrist pulling her right into her embrace "MPH! N-nhho..." she tried to murmur something only for a shiver to make her melt into the red eyed girl.

Catra's entire body leaned in, head tilting backwards as she whimpered under her as clawed fingers nicked at Scarlet's arms while she ran her fingers through the back of her hair holding her head in place. Scarlet sucked in sharply through her nose as their fangs pushed together yet neither stopped their awkward and desperate mashing of lips.

Finally, after hungrily making the feline a panting mess she pulled back as another set of arms wrapped around her waist "w-what

was that?” Catra stuttered out quietly in her lap, head tilted down.

“I- my mom and dad said it was a kiss.... And that you should only do it with the people you cared the most about and wanted to stay with forever, the ones you wanted to create a.....” heat suddenly surged up her face as she realized what they’d meant, yet when she looked up.....

“A what?” Adora asked, pulling them both closer and almost completely over into her lap.

“S-shouldn’t you two? Don’t you want to?” Scarlet chuckled nervously, staring at the generator thrumming nearby again. The only thing probably keeping them warm so high up at this time of year... Even though for some reason she didn’t feel cold whatsoever... Not even the slight lingers like normal.

The two glanced at each other shyly, Adora cocking her head with an arched brow and Catra squirmed in place but leaned closer “we’re still talking about this...” she whispered as the blond slipped her fingers under the brunet's chin.

Hiiih! she made a high-pitched noise, still panting slightly from her previous session. But Adora seemed so eager, and the feline found herself whimpering as she was squished in between them. Scarlet noted on the way she trembled; tail wrapped around her waist while being swallowed up by Adora’s embrace.

The air seemed thick with heat, those two going at it as if their lives depended on their lips being stuck together. The feeling had been so intense, electrifying even as soft yet tender brushes against her mouth had filled her world. A string of saliva still connected them as the Blond pulled away with an incredibly proud smile which the feline couldn't stop staring at, pupils widened into plates.

Adora's chest rose and fell heavily but she was still beaming as if she'd become the sun. Scarlet could even swear her irises had become blue rivers of light as she ran her thumb over Catra's cheek with such a content expression that the feline just leaned into it.

"That was some magical juice" Catra murmured to the two others chuckles.

"What the hell did they put in that bottle" Scarlet asked, resting her head on the Blond's firm shoulder.

It bounced slightly as Adora snorted, swirling the last contents of the bottle around "I don't know and honestly? I don't care either" she added before taking one last swig.

"Hey, I still wanted some...." Scarlet whined when an almost feral look glinted in the Blond's shimmering eyes.

"Oh?"

“Mhmpf! Hmmmf...” a droplet of whatever that drink was rolled over Scarlet’s lip as Adora locked them together.

No more of the drink spilled over as Adora firmly kept them together, it pouring into her mouth while the tips of their tongues brushed hesitantly before prodding each other curiously. Scarlet simply accepted, swallowing the drink as Adora almost vibrated w-with power?

“Haaah.... Holy shit...” Scarlet gasped “y-your magic.... It’s fucking flaring” Adora blinked and stared at her hands.

“W-what do you mean?”

“Your eyes they are.... Glowing” Catra gawked, quickly grabbing Adora’s chin which was quite easy since both of them were sitting in the Blond’s lap.

“I.....” Adora stared forward, seemingly deep in thought.

Scarlet’s gaze fell over the horizon, the city and most importantly the military complex where they trained as anxiety squeezed around her heart “m-maybe we should leave”

“You wanna go back? Now?” Catra asked.

“No, no I mean maybe we shouldn’t be here, in the Horde” both suddenly looked at her, that shimmer in Adora’s eyes dimming.

“W-why? Where would we even go?”

“I-it’s just a feeling but there is a lot more out there than what either of you think, we could go anywhere” Scarlet faintly remembered a map on her old homes wall. Etheria was massive, and they could just leave, there had to be some place which didn’t try to either kill her or wouldn’t hate them all for being Horde cadets....

“Is it because of what Weaver did?” Catra snapped her out of her thoughts and the vampire stared into the middle of her palm.

“No, yes, I-I can’t, I’m not sure but why stay here? We should at least go through the pros and cons of staying and leaving”

“What do you mean? What did Weaver do?” Adora hurriedly asked, eyebrows creasing as that light in her eyes strengthened again for some reason.

“I wasn't going to say anything until later but.... Scarlet can’t remember the week before this one, this isn't the first time but, do you even remember why she wanted to give you *special training?*”

“Umm-”

* **SNAP** *

All of their attentions suddenly focused on an icy cold running up their spines as the generator nearby abruptly died. Again, it felt as if hundreds of eyes were watching her, and Scarlet’s mind came to a horrifying conclusion.

“S-she knows where we are....” she murmured defeatedly, did she only know where they were or could she hear to o-or even see?....

A chill ran through the air, and they all shot up as a single red eyed shadow slunk out from under the vampire “troublesome thoughts you’ve put in their minds indeed, now, Scarlet, **what do you think you’re doing?** ” darkness spilled over the rooftops edge like waves while tentacles sprouted out of those shadows.

Scarlet’s heart constricted as her vision blurred and breathing intensified. Air almost didn’t want to reach her lungs and a cold sweat suddenly drenched her when an arm pulled her back.

“Explain, what did you do to her?!” Adora growled out as that red masked individual tilted their head to the side.

“What is there to explain, and why....” Weaver sighed as those shadows shot forward and wrapped around Scarlet’s limbs “all this work and progress and now... I have to do this because of a teenager's hormones...”

Sadly, none of them would remember what happened on their sixteenth induction day, the first and only time Adora would openly defy Shadow Weaver with all her might before Thaymor... No, they wouldn’t remember any of it, even the days following up to it until it was already far too late...

Chapter End Notes

So I'm guessing you already know what for example happened to the magicat queen and her mate and brother during the main timeline.... Weaver kills them all but C'yra gets captured and basically tested on for the little time she's still alive after their confrontation.

C'yra at least according to the wiki and a couple other sources get's captured before being insinuated that she dies. After which a new king takes over, who that is I have no idea since I haven't seen the 1985 show. Of course what happens to the magicats in the reboot is up for debate but even so it wouldn't have necessarily been much different from the old show.

And of course if Weaver hadn't left a shadow spy with Scarlet? Would they even stay in the Horde after this night? What do you think?

Thank you for reading and consider leaving you're overall thoughts they are very much welcome as always.

End Notes

Now I know the ending to chapter 1 here is similar to another chapter I did but considering the circumstance I didn't feel it appropriate not to have this happen considering what they went through. I did consider having another scene but I re made it enough times and just by switching two positions really works as a metaphor for their life in this time at least. Sort of.

Also just on Catra I'm like a hundred percent certain she'd have gotten bullied or something towards that extent in the Horde. A lot of her confidence has always been a façade and while I'm sure she wouldn't have taken any of it lying down, her personality would've made her a target.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!